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Nearly 12 crore women like me have received safe maternity care



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— FLOWS HOLD: HORMUZ CROSSED, MANGALORE CARGO IN —

Fuel stocks intact, avoid panic buying, says govt

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government on Saturday urged citizens to avoid panic buying of petrol, diesel and LPG, saying fuel supplies remain adequate despite disruptions linked to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said the government is taking proactive steps to ensure the uninterrupted availability of petroleum products and cooking gas, while advising people to rely only on official information and conserve energy.

The government has prioritised domestic LPG and piped natural gas (PNG) supplies, particularly for households, hospitals and essential services, and has implemented measures to boost refinery output and manage demand, including extending LPG refill intervals.

Authorities have also stepped up enforcement against hoarding and black marketing, conducting more than 3,700 raids and issuing around 1,000 show-cause notices to LPG distributors, with 27 dealerships suspended so far.

Despite supply pressures from the geopolitical situation, there are no reports of LPG shortages at distributor points, the ministry said in a



Customers gather at an HP Gas dealership office to book LPG cylinders amid a supply crisis, at Beldanga, in Murshidabad district of West Bengal PTI

STAY CALM

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statement, adding that about 51 lakh cylinders were delivered on Friday and online bookings accounted for 95 per cent of the total demand.

Commercial LPG supplies have been capped at 70 per cent

of pre-crisis levels, while alternative fuels, such as kerosene and coal, are being deployed to ease demand.

On natural gas, the government said it is ensuring full supplies to

Centre: No pay snag with Iran

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India said on Saturday that there are no payment issues with Iran for crude imports and that refiners continue to source oil from the country, as well as from a wide range of global suppliers.

In a post on X, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas dismissed reports that an oil tanker carrying Iranian crude had rerouted mid-voyage from its previously indicated destination of India, which would have marked the first such shipment in nearly seven years, to China, saying the claims overlooked standard industry practice where cargoes can change destination during transit based on trade optimisation and operational flexibility.

Terming as “factually incorrect” assertions that the cargo was diverted from its previously indicated

Continued on P4

War: Double crash, single chase

Trump reminds Iran of deadline: 48 hrs before hell will rain down

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: The search is on for one missing US service member while another was rescued after two US warplanes went down in separate incidents including the first shoot-down since the Iran war began nearly five weeks ago.

The incidents occurred just two days after President Donald Trump said in a national address that the US has “beaten and completely decimated Iran”. In a post on Truth Social, Trump warned in his latest salvo against Iran, saying that if Tehran does not adhere to his deadline to open the Strait of Hormuz, “hell will rain down on them.”

“Remember when I gave Iran ten days to MAKE A DEAL or OPEN UP THE HORMUZ STRAIT. Time is running out - 48 hours before all Hell will rain down on them. Glory be to GOD! President DONALD J. TRUMP,” he wrote on Truth Social. Earlier, Trump had extended the deadline to reopen the critical energy chokepoint by 10 days, pushing it to April 6 after expressing optimism about ongoing talks with Iran.

Officials said that one fighter jet was shot down in Iran. A US crew member from that plane was rescued, but a second was missing, and a US military search-and-rescue operation was underway. The US military pressed ahead



People gather at the site of an Israeli airstrike that hit a building in the southern port city of Tyre, Lebanon, on Saturday AP/PTI

KEY POINTS

» Officials said that one fighter jet was shot down in Iran. A US crew member from that plane was rescued, but a second was missing, and a US military search-and-rescue operation was underway

» The plane, identified by Iran as a US F-15E Strike Eagle, was one of two attacked on Friday, with one service member rescued and at least one missing

It was the first time the US lost aircraft in Iranian territory during the war, now in its sixth week, and could mark a new turning point in the campaign

Separately, Iranian state media said a US A-10 attack aircraft crashed in the Persian Gulf after being struck by Iranian defense forces

Iran says strike hit close to Bushehr nuclear facility, killing guard and damaging building

in a frantic search for a missing pilot over a remote area in southwestern Iran, after the Middle Eastern country shot down an American warplane and called on people to turn the pilot in, promising a reward.

The plane, identified by Iran as a US F-15E Strike Eagle, was one of two attacked on Friday, with one service member rescued and at least one missing. It was the first time the US lost aircraft in Iranian territory during the war, now in its sixth week, and could mark a new turning point in the campaign.

Separately, Iranian state

media said a US A-10 attack aircraft crashed in the Persian Gulf after being struck by Iranian defense forces.

The war now entering its sixth week is destabilising economies around the world as Iran responds to the US and Israeli attacks by targeting the Gulf region's energy infrastructure and tightening its grip on oil and natural gas shipments through the Strait of Hormuz.

Mediators from Pakistan, Turkey and Egypt are still working to bring the United States and Iran back to the negotiating table, according

to two regional officials. The regional powers are working on a compromise to bridge the gap between the American and Iranian demands to stop the war and reopen the crucial Strait of Hormuz, they said.

They said the yet-to-be finalised compromise aims at paving the way for both sides to meet in Pakistan. It includes a cessation of hostilities for a certain period of time to allow a diplomatic settlement, according to a regional official involved in the efforts and a Gulf diplomat briefed on the matter. Continued on P4

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Open well claims family of 9

Nashik: 6 kids among the dead; CM orders safety audit

MPOST BUREAU

NASHIK: Nine members of a family, including six children, were killed after their car fell into an open well in Maharashtra's Nashik district, police said on Saturday.

The accident occurred in the Shivaji Nagar area of Dindori town around 10 pm on Friday, an official said.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis expressed grief over the deaths of children in the tragic incident, and said that he has ordered an immediate safety audit of open wells in public areas.

According to the police, the victims were returning home after attending a function at a banquet hall in the area when their car fell into a well on the roadside near the venue. Personnel from the local police and emergency services arrived at the scene and retrieved the car and its occupants with the help of two cranes and swimmers around midnight.

The victims were members of



Maharashtra Water Resources Minister Girish Mahajan, centre, along with officials inspects the accident site; (inset) wreckage of a car which fell into a well PTI



PRELIMINARY INFORMATION INDICATED THAT THE WELL HAD A LOW BOUNDARY WALL AND WAS IN THE MIDDLE OF A FREQUENTLY ACCESSED AREA

the Dargude family from Indore village in Dindori taluka, the official said.

The deceased were identified as Sunil Dattu Dargude (32), his wife

Reshma, Asha Anil Dargude (32), and six children from the family, including five girls in the age group of seven to 14 years and an 11-year-old boy.

The bodies were brought to the government hospital in Dindori, the official said, adding that a case has been registered.

State Disaster Management Minister Girish Mahajan visited the accident spot. He said that the administration has been directed to close the well, Continued on P4

HAILS DECISIVE LEADERSHIP

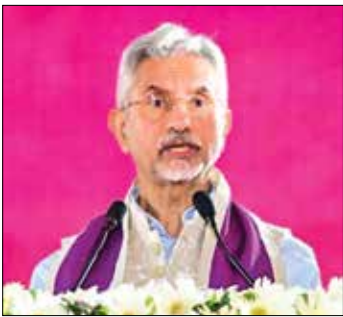
India resilient amid global shocks: EAM

MPOST BUREAU

RAIPUR: India has emerged solidly as a resilient global power, successfully navigating a series of external shocks that have tested the nation's economic and diplomatic strength, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar asserted on Saturday, in an apparent reference to the ongoing West Asia conflict.

Addressing the 15th convocation ceremony of the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Raipur, Jaishankar identified the triple challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic, ongoing global conflicts, and climate change as the disruptions of the decade, asserting that India has emerged solidly from these shocks.

He said that these three factors have impacted daily lives to an “unimaginable degree.” While the pandemic transformed



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar PTI

global work and life, the minister said that current conflicts have deeply impacted even distant societies, a testimony to the depth of globalisation.

He noted that India's ability to manage domestic and international challenges has solidified its position among the world's top five economies.

TURBULENT WORLD

» While the pandemic transformed global work and life, the minister said that current conflicts have deeply impacted even distant societies, a testimony to the depth of globalisation

» ‘We are now among the top five economies. No one can dispute that multiple global shocks have recently tested our resilience, and India has come through that solidly’

» ‘We have managed both domestic and external challenges fairly successfully’

“We are now among the top five economies. No one can dispute that multiple global shocks have recently tested our resilience, and India has come through that solidly,” he said, adding, “We have managed both domestic and external challenges fairly successfully.”

More inclusive growth, rep-

resentative politics and decisive leadership have created a new foundation from which the country can now harbour higher aspirations, he said.

“We have not only embraced the digital revolution enthusiastically, but actually purposefully applied it through our lives.

Continued on P4

SNOW BLANKET



Fresh snowfall blankets Machel Bhawan Mandir and its surroundings in the remote Padder area of Kishtwar district, in Jammu and Kashmir, on Saturday PTI

Hills white, plains wet



People walk down a street amid fresh snowfall at Keylong, in Lahaul and Spiti district, Himachal Pradesh

NEW DELHI: The higher reaches of Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir on Saturday witnessed fresh snowfall as a spell of wet weather gripped north India, bringing rainfall to parts of Delhi, Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan.

Rains and hailstorms have continued to lash the northern states intermittently this week, with wheat growers in Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan staring at major losses due to crop damage.

The national capital, meanwhile, witnessed rain during the night between Friday and Saturday in isolated areas. However, the maximum temperature in the city dropped due to persistent cloudy conditions throughout the day.

In Jammu and Kashmir, the snowfall also led to the closure of many important inter-district roads, officials said.

The Met Office warned of brief but intense heavy showers in isolated parts, which may lead to flash floods and landslides at a few vulnerable places and water-logging in a few low-lying areas. See P4

Pharma exports rise over 5% to \$28.29 billion till Feb FY26

‘Currently valued at around \$60 billion, pharmaceutical sector is projected to grow to \$130 billion by 2030’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: India’s pharmaceutical exports stood at \$28.29 billion up to February of financial year 2025-26, registering a growth of more than 5 per cent compared to the same period last year, a top official said on Saturday.

K Raja Bhanu, Director General of the Pharmaceuticals Export Promotion Council of India (Pharmexcil), said the sector, currently valued at around \$60 billion, is projected to grow to \$130 billion by 2030.

“Despite global challenges, pharmaceutical exports have been among the few sectors to maintain growth momentum. Exports during April–February FY26 stood at \$28.29 billion, reflecting a growth of 5.6 per cent compared to the same period in FY25, led by formulations, biologicals, vaccines and AYUSH products,” he said, addressing the inaugural session of the ‘Chintan Shivir: Scaling Up Pharma Exports’.

Rajesh Agrawal, Secretary in the Department of Commerce, said that irrespective of whether targets are met in dollar terms, exports would show growth in rupee terms as the Indian currency continues to weaken against the US dollar.



‘Irrespective of whether targets are met in dollar terms, exports would show growth in rupee terms as the Indian currency continues to weaken against the US dollar’

“The target we have set appears difficult to meet, but we will remain on a positive trajectory,” Agrawal said. Bhanu added that exports reached \$30.47 billion in FY25, marking a year-on-year growth of 9.4 per cent despite global pricing pressures and trade volatility. Pharmexcil Chairman Namit Joshi said India is likely to end the current financial year at levels similar to FY25.

Looking ahead, Bhanu said Pharmexcil aims to achieve \$65 billion in exports by 2030

through policy prioritisation, market diversification beyond traditional geographies, increased FDI inflows and improved regulatory efficiency. India ranks third globally in pharmaceutical production by volume, with exports reaching over 200 markets worldwide, he said. Notably, more than 60 per cent of India’s pharmaceutical exports are directed towards highly regulated markets, underscoring the industry’s quality and compliance standards.

Highlights

» ‘Exports reached \$30.47 billion in FY25, marking a year-on-year growth of 9.4% despite global pricing pressures and trade volatility’

» Pharmexcil Chairman Namit Joshi said India is likely to end the current financial year at levels similar to FY25

» Pharmexcil aims to achieve \$65 billion in exports by 2030, K Raja Bhanu, Director General Pharmexcil said

The US accounts for 34 per cent of exports, followed by Europe at 19 per cent, he added.

Joshi said tariff-related issues in 2025 led to higher procurement of medicines worth \$1.6 billion in the US, above normal levels, which is expected to impact FY26 figures.

“That is why we expect to end up close to last year’s performance, with some growth coming from that,” he said.

He added that exact figures would be available only after the March data is released.

‘If West Asia crisis continues Indian exports to other parts of world will get impacted’

Indian exports during last fiscal were expected to remain on a positive trajectory despite crisis, Central Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: If the West Asia conflict continues, India’s exports to other parts of the world will also be impacted, Central Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Saturday.

Indian exports during the last financial year were expected to remain on a positive trajectory despite the crisis, he added.

Addressing a press conference on the sidelines of ‘Chintan Shivir - Scaling Up Pharma Exports’, Agrawal said that because of the West Asia crisis, there was definitely an impact last month on both imports and exports, as energy is a major part of the Indian import market.

“West Asia is also an important market. Around 12-13 per cent of our exports go to the region. So, that will directly get impacted. And if it goes on for long, maybe our exports to other parts of the world will also get impacted as some of the value chains will rotate back. We are cognizant of it,” the official told reporters.

Replying to a query, he said the exact impact of the West Asia crisis on Indian exports will be known in a couple of weeks.

He said the Centre is trying to see that the supply chains get minimum impact as far as possible, even as the government is ready with some numbers going down, as far as export and import are concerned.



‘Because of the West Asia crisis, there was definitely an impact last month on both imports and exports, as energy is a major part of the Indian import market,’ the commerce secretary said

“And I assume, it will not only be a one-way traffic, in terms of export going down, but it will also be imports having some downfall,” he said.

He further said that even if the war ends, the impact of the crisis will be there for the next few months or years, depending on which supply chain or which infrastructure has been impacted.

“So, at this juncture, it will be very difficult to take a very long-term view on it,” the official said. The idea was that the industry should become self-reliant to combat these external challenges, which may keep coming, he opined. Agrawal said that there has been some impact coming to pharma sector in terms of some of the important intermediates and solvents as the supply chain is getting impacted. All arms of the government are engaged to see how they can prioritise the limited supply of

Key Points

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» The exact impact of the West Asia crisis on Indian exports will be known in a couple of weeks, Agrawal said

» ‘The Centre is trying to see that supply chains get minimum impact as far as possible, even as the govt is ready with some numbers going down, as far as export & import are concerned’

LPG, and it is being resolved to the largest extent possible by even diversifying imports, buying from other sources also, he said.

“So, as we are able to resolve that overall supply, we will try to alleviate some of the pain in every sector. The Pharma sector will be one of the priority sectors,” he said.

The commerce secretary said that the industry and the government are sitting and trying to figure out what can be done to make the supply chains more resilient.

IDBI Bank reports 16% rise in loan growth to ₹2.53 lakh cr in March qtr

NEW DELHI: LIC-controlled IDBI Bank on Saturday reported a 16 per cent increase in loan growth to Rs 2.53 lakh crore for the fourth quarter ended March 2026.

Its total advances were Rs 2.18 lakh crore at the end of March 31, 2025, IDBI Bank said in a regulatory filing.

The lender reported a 12 per cent rise in total deposits to Rs 3.46 lakh crore from Rs 3.1 lakh crore at the end of the fourth quarter of the preceding financial year.

The total business of the bank increased 14 per cent to Rs 6 lakh crore compared to Rs 5.28 lakh crore at the end of March 31, 2025.

Meanwhile, Kotak Mahindra Bank also reported higher credit growth versus deposit expansion. The bank registered



IDBI Bank’s total advances were Rs 2.18 lakh crore at the end of March 31, 2025

a 16.2 per cent rise in advances to Rs 4.95 lakh crore from Rs 4.26 lakh crore in the fourth quarter of the preceding fiscal.

It reported a 14.7 per cent increase in total deposits to Rs

5.72 lakh crore from Rs 4.99 lakh crore at the end of the fourth quarter of FY25, Kotak Mahindra Bank said in a regulatory filing.

AU Small Finance Bank also reported a higher credit growth vis-a-vis deposit expansion. The bank posted a 25.1 per cent rise in advances to Rs 1.36 lakh crore against Rs 1.08 lakh crore in the fourth quarter of FY25.

The lender reported a 22.8 per cent increase in total deposits to Rs 1.52 lakh crore compared to Rs 1.24 lakh crore at the end of the fourth quarter of FY25, AU Small Finance Bank (SFB) said in a regulatory filing.

However, the bank’s low-cost CASA (current account savings account) ratio declined to 28.4 per cent of the total deposits from 29.2 per cent at the end of March 2025. PTI

HDFC Bank posts 12% credit growth in Q4

NEW DELHI: The country’s second-largest lender HDFC Bank on Saturday reported a 12 per cent credit growth to Rs 29.6 lakh crore for the March quarter.

Its total advances were Rs 26.43 lakh crore at the end of March 31, 2025, HDFC Bank said in a regulatory filing.

The lender reported a 14.4 per cent rise in total deposits to Rs 31.05 lakh crore from Rs 27.14 lakh crore at the end of the fourth quarter of the preceding financial year.

During the period, CASA deposits recorded a growth of 12.3 per cent to Rs 10.6 lakh crore compared to Rs 9.4 lakh crore in the year-ago period, it said.

The bank’s period-end time deposits were approximately Rs 20.45 lakh crore as of March 31, 2026, a growth of around 15.5 per cent over Rs 17.7 lakh crore



The lender reported a 14.4% rise in total deposits to Rs 31.05 lakh crore from Rs 27.14 lakh crore at the end of Q4 FY2024-25

as of March 31, 2025.

During the quarter, Atanu Chakraborty abruptly resigned as chairman of the HDFC Bank, citing ethical concerns

effective March 18.

This is the first time that the part-time chairman of HDFC Bank left in the middle, raising concerns over the functioning.

“Certain happenings and practices within the bank, that I have observed over the last two years, are not in congruence with my personal Values and Ethics. This is the basis of my aforementioned decision,” he had said in his resignation letter dated March 17.

In a letter addressed to the Chairman of Governance, Nomination, and Remuneration Committee, H K Bhanwala, Chakraborty said that “there are no other material reasons for my resignation other than those stated above”.

It is to be noted that Chakraborty was appointed part-time chairman effective May 5, 2021, almost a year after retirement as Economic Affairs Secretary.

His term was extended for another three years in 2024 till May 4, 2027.

Chakraborty, a 1985 batch IAS officer of Gujarat cadre, retired as Secretary of the Department of Economic Affairs in April 2020. Prior to that, he was the Secretary of the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM). Both departments come under the Finance Ministry.

Chakraborty became chairman during the reverse merger process of the bank with the parent entity HDFC Ltd, a leading mortgage firm in the country.

The merger of HDFC Ltd with HDFC Bank became effective on July 1, 2023, creating a financial behemoth with a combined balance sheet of over Rs 18 lakh crore. PTI

‘Energy mix needed to meet long-term power demand’

JAIPUR: Union Power Secretary Pankaj Agarwal on Saturday stressed the need for an “energy mix” approach to meet long-term power demand and asked Rajasthan power utilities to accelerate projects based on a combination of renewable and conventional sources.

Agarwal said bundling renewable and non-renewable energy sources would help manage the rising electricity demand more efficiently.

He noted that decentralised solar projects under the PM-KUSUM Scheme have gained momentum in Rajasthan, but also flagged challenges related to the grid integration of solar power.

The Union Power Secretary emphasised the need to strengthen grid stability and to develop battery energy storage systems in a timely manner to ensure an uninterrupted power supply during peak hours, as per an official statement.

He also reviewed issues such as daytime electricity supply to the agriculture sector in 24 districts, loss reduction measures, progress of smart metering, and resource adequacy planning.

Officials informed the meeting that around 3,800 MW of capacity has been installed in the state under the PM-KUSUM scheme so far. PTI

Multiple state govts to borrow ₹18,159 crore through Reserve Bank SGS auction on April 7

NEW DELHI: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has announced that multiple state governments will raise a total of Rs 18,159 crore through the auction of State Government Securities (SGS), scheduled to be conducted on April 7, 2026.

According to the Central Bank release, the securities will be issued through an auction conducted on the RBI’s Core Banking Solution platform, E-Kuber.

The auction will include borrowings by several states, with varying tenors and structures, including both fresh issuances and re-issues of existing securities.

Among the participating states, Andhra Pradesh plans

to raise Rs 2,200 crore through two securities with tenors of 12 and 25 years. Himachal Pradesh will raise Rs 900 crore with a 10-year tenor, while Maharashtra will borrow Rs 3,600 crore through three securities worth Rs 800, 1,600 and 1,200 with tenors of 5, 13 and 23 years, respectively. Meghalaya will raise Rs 259 crore via a 10-year security.

Punjab intends to raise Rs 1,500 crore through security with a tenor of ten years. Rajasthan will issue three securities worth Rs 3,600 crore through a mix of fresh securities and re-issues.

These include re-issuance of 7.33 per cent Rajasthan SGS 2031, issued on March



‘Securities will be issued through an auction conducted on the RBI’s Core Banking Solution platform, E-Kuber

25, 2026. Meanwhile, Telangana will borrow Rs 3900 crore

through 2 securities worth Rs 2,000 and Rs 1,900 with a tenor of 17 years and 30 years each.

“Both competitive and non-competitive bids for the auction should be submitted in electronic format on the Reserve Bank of India Core Banking Solution (E-Kuber) system on April 07, 2026 (Tuesday),” the release said.

Individual investors can also place bids as per the non-competitive scheme through the Retail Direct portal

The results of the auction will be announced on April 07, 2026 (Tuesday), and payment by successful bidders will be made during banking hours on April 08, 2026 (Wednesday). AGENCIES

Srinivasan quits Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution

NEW DELHI: Veteran industrialist Venu Srinivasan, a trustee on Tata Trusts, has resigned from the Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charitable Institution, according to sources.

Although he cited other business commitments for his resignation from one of the smaller trusts in the Tata Trusts, the development followed a challenge from Mehli Mistry, a former trustee of the Tata Trusts.

Comments from Srinivasan and Tata Trusts could not be obtained immediately.

Mistry had challenged the appointments of Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh to the board of Bai Hirabai Jamsetji Tata Navsari Charita-

The development followed challenge from Mehli Mistry, a former trustee of the Tata Trusts against appointment of Venu Srinivasan & Vijay Singh to the institution’s board

ble Institution in a complaint to the Maharashtra Charity Commissioner.

He claimed that Srinivasan and Singh do not satisfy the criteria laid out in the trust deed.

Among Mistry’s main con-

dition was the specific conditions mandated in the deed that includes practice of the Parsi Zoroastrian faith and residency requirements in Mumbai.

Last year, Tata Trusts was rocked by infighting among trustees. The matter reached the government, with the top brass of the Tata group, including Noel Tata and Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran, meeting Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

Subsequently, the government told the trusts to resolve the issue amicably and not let their differences spill into the public, considering the significance of the Tata Group on India’s economy. PTI

EU-India free trade pact likely to boost India’s competitiveness in some sectors: EY report

The report highlights that the recently announced EU-India Free Trade Agreement is expected to have limited overall macroeconomic impact on Europe

NEW DELHI: Europe’s economic outlook remains fragile due to persistent global trade tensions and geopolitical risks, which may have spill-over effects on India’s trade and competitiveness, according to EY’s European Economic Outlook (March 2026).

The report notes that evolving trade policies, tariffs and geopolitical uncertainties continue to influence Europe’s economic trajectory,

with potential implications for global trade flows and competition with countries such as India. It highlights that the recently announced EU-India Free Trade Agreement (FTA) is expected to have limited overall macroeconomic impact on Europe but could create notable sectoral shifts.

Certain European industries may face increased competition from India. While sectors like minerals could

benefit from improved access to inputs, the clothing industry may come under pressure from competitive Indian producers, the report said.

Global trade tensions remain a key headwind. EY estimates that US-imposed tariffs could reduce EU GDP growth by 0.5 percentage points in 2026, with Ireland and Nordic countries likely to be most affected.

Despite these challenges,



the euro area is projected to grow at a modest pace. Growth is expected to slow to 1.3 per

CLOSER LOOK

» While sectors like minerals could benefit from improved access to inputs, the clothing industry may come under pressure from competitive Indian producers, report said

» For India, the report suggests that deeper trade ties with Europe & growing competitiveness in sectors like textiles could create opportunities despite global uncertainties

cent in 2026 from 1.5 per cent in 2025, before gradually recovering to 1.4 per cent in

2027 and 1.5 per cent during 2028-29.

Geopolitical tensions in

the Middle East could further impact energy prices and economic activity. The report estimates such risks could raise euro area inflation by 0.3 percentage points and lower GDP by 0.2 per cent in 2026, with more severe disruptions posing greater risks.

Structural issues, including ageing populations and labour shortages, are also expected to weigh on long-term growth, particularly in parts of Central,

Eastern and Southern Europe.

However, investment in emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence could support productivity, with AI projected to boost Western Europe’s GDP by up to 4 per cent by 2033. For India, the report suggests that deeper trade ties with Europe and growing competitiveness in sectors like textiles could create opportunities despite global uncertainties. AGENCIES

Delhi drone policy takes flight as govt targets disasters & smart governance

Charts drone ecosystem with subsidies, training and governance tech

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government's proposed drone policy is likely to focus on creating drone research clusters, establishing dedicated flight testing facilities, enabling the use of drones in traffic management, and providing subsidies to support the drone ecosystem, officials said on Saturday.

According to officials, in a recently held meeting, the policy framework was discussed, where plans to rope in the Drone Federation of India (DFI), a leading non-government organisation in this area, were approved.

Earlier this year, the government set up a committee under the chairmanship of the IT department secretary to examine the feasibility of the Delhi Drone Policy. "A comprehensive drone policy is being planned to ensure safe and regulated drone operations. Along with this, the government is working on an IT dashboard,



The government plans to rope in the Drone Federation of India

a digital monitoring system to provide effective governance," IT minister Pankaj Singh said.

According to officials, the policy's key objectives include regulating drone usage to prevent misuse, enabling government agencies to use drones for surveillance and mapping, and strengthening integration

with the DGCA's Digital Sky platform.

"The Delhi Drone Policy is focused around five focus areas, including public awareness and enforcement under these events, outreach, zoning signage, sensitisation workshops, safety framework and counter-drone standard

Slum rehab policy in plans

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government plans to provide slum dwellers modern facilities such as shopping complexes, parking spaces and e-rickshaw charging points under a new rehabilitation and resettlement policy being prepared, a source said.

Facilities under consideration include schools, Jan Suvidha Kendras, and dedicated sanitation arrangements for women, according to the government's proposed policy plan. The source said the policy is in the final stage and will likely be finalised this month.

The government also plans to extend the eligibility cut-off date under the existing policy by around 10 years from January 1, 2015, to January 1, 2025, making many slum dwellers eligible for permanent housing, he said.

operating procedures will be worked out," the official said.

Additionally, government drone usage will involve policing, disaster response, and traffic management in the city.

"The policy also intends to plan the sector usage of drones in real estate projects, telecom and media," officials added.

According to the plan, the government is considering capacity-building initiatives

like drone awareness workshops in schools, establishing centres of excellence, setting up Remote Pilot Training Organisations (RPTO), and launching pilot training projects.

"A supporting drone ecosystem, facilities like drone clusters for research, flight testing facilities, and subsidy and state GST reimbursement could be part of the policy," the official further said.

CM says there is no shortage of LPG, asks Delhiites to not panic



Rekha Gupta during a roadshow in West Bengal on Saturday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday that there is no shortage of domestic or commercial LPG in the national capital and urged Delhiites "not to panic".

She exhorted people not to crowd gas agencies and LPG centres. "Avoid visiting LPG godowns. The administration is making efforts to ensure an uninterrupted LPG supply to people. Strict action will be taken against violators," Gupta said.

Sharing the latest government data, the chief minister said on April 3, over 1,11,504 bookings were recorded, while three oil marketing companies delivered 1,26,379 cylinders,

clearing pending backlogs.

The average delivery time for domestic LPG cylinders in Delhi has now been reduced to four days, ensuring timely, reliable doorstep service for consumers, she said. Officials from the Delhi Government's Department of Food, Supplies and Consumer Affairs said supplies have exceeded demand in recent days. The CM said the Delhi Police raided 22 locations across the city to bust rackets, registering one FIR at the North Rohini Police Station, where six illegally stored cylinders were found.

A control room with a dedicated number (011-23379836) has been set up, and complaints are being closely monitored to check black marketing.

Cloudy conditions to prevail, AQI 'moderate'

NEW DELHI: The national capital experienced a slight increase in minimum temperature on Saturday, while the maximum temperature decreased due to persistent cloudy conditions throughout the day.

Although the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a yellow alert for the day, only isolated areas of Delhi received light rain during the night between Friday and Saturday. On Saturday morning, the Sadarjung weather station, a key representative of the city's weather, did not record any rain, while other stations reported varying amounts: Palam received 1.9 mm of rain between 11.30 pm on Friday and 2.30 am on Saturday; Lodhi Road recorded 0.3 mm; Ridge also noted 1.9 mm; Ayanagar experienced 5.8 mm; and Pitampura saw 0.5 mm during the same period. No additional rain was observed until 5.30 pm, according to IMD data.

The minimum temperature rose to 20.7 degrees Celsius, which is 1.9 degrees above normal and 1.5 degrees higher than the previous day. AGENCIES

Gurugram: Woman 'raped' by former councillor; booked

GURUGRAM: A 30-year-old woman was allegedly raped multiple times by a former councillor and his associate under the pretext of mediating a dowry case with her estranged husband in the Pataudi area here, police said on Saturday.

The woman had filed a dowry case against her husband and had been living with her parents. Following this, the accused contacted her and promised a reconciliation with her husband, they said.

The complainant told the police that in October 2024, the accused -- former Pataudi councillor Zahid and his associate, Sonu -- lured her to a hotel in Heli-landi and gang-raped her. After which, they raped her multiple times in different hotels in Pataudi and also threatened her into silence.

"On February 17 this year, Zahid called me to his house, where Sonu was already present, and they both raped me. When I said to report the matter to the police, they threatened to kill me. While I was on my way to report the matter, Zahid and his wife assaulted me in the market", the complainant said. A case under was registered. AGENCIES

4 booked in Ggm for assaulting man

NEW DELHI: Four men have been booked for allegedly sexually assaulting a young man, filming the act and stealing Rs 10,000 from him, police said on Saturday.

The incident occurred on Friday evening, when the victim was returning after dropping an acquaintance at Pataudi Road railway station.

The victim, in his complaint, mentioned that while returning from the station, he was intercepted by four men -- Sonu, his friend Teju and two others -- from Khandewla village, near the Pataudi bus stand.

The men forcibly took him to a place where they allegedly stripped and sexually assaulted him, and filmed the whole incident, the police said. AGENCIES

Hari Nagar murder: Mother held; father and brother in custody

NEW DELHI: The mother of a 19-year-old woman, who was smothered to death allegedly by her family over her relationship with a cousin, was arrested on Saturday, police said.

The postmortem report revealed the cause of death was smothering, police said, adding that the victim's brother allegedly held her hands, and the mother and father suffocated her to death using a pillow.

The victim's mother, Rabiya Khatun, was arrested a day after her father, Mohammad Maneer (55) and her brother Meraj Ali (19) were arrested, they said.

The incident came to light on April 1 after a PCR call was received around 2 pm alleging that a woman had been killed by her family and her body was being taken for her last rites,

Decomposed body found in bag near Moti Nagar

NEW DELHI: A decomposed body of an unidentified man was found stuffed inside a plastic bag near a factory in west Delhi's Moti Nagar area on Saturday, an official said. The incident came to light after a PCR call was received at Moti Nagar police station regarding a suspicious bag lying outside a factory in Prem Nagar, he said. "On reaching the spot, police found a large white plastic bag tied with a rope lying near the gate of a factory premises. The bag was emitting a foul smell, prompting suspicion," the officer said. AGENCIES

police said. "The family members saw her with a man. She was beaten up and even confined in the house for some days," a source said.

When the police team reached the spot, they found that the body was being taken

for burial. Acting on suspicion of honour killing, the burial process was stopped, and the body was taken into possession, an officer said.

The victim had been in a relationship with a man for the past two years. AGENCIES

Club brawl turns violent in Preet Vihar, man shot in leg

NEW DELHI: A 21-year-old man sustained a gunshot injury outside a club in east Delhi's Preet Vihar in the early hours of Saturday following an altercation, an official said.

The incident was reported around 4.30 am when Preet Vihar police station received a PCR call regarding the admission of a man with gunshot wounds at Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital.

According to the police, the injured, Sameer, is a resident

of Noor-e-Ilahi in northeast Delhi, and his condition was stated to be stable.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that Sameer had gone to a club in Preet Vihar along with his friends. Later, two of their acquaintances joined them at the venue. During their time inside the club, an argument broke out between one of Sameer's friends and another man who was present there along with his associates, an officer said. AGENCIES

Man held from Ghaziabad for job fraud

NEW DELHI: A 28-year-old man has been arrested from Ghaziabad for allegedly cheating a Delhi woman of more than Rs 1.51 lakh on the pretext of filing a job application, police said on Saturday.

Accused Keshav Kumar Karn, a resident of Ghaziabad's Khoda Colony, was apprehended by a team from the Cyber police station in Shahdara district. A mobile phone and a SIM card were recovered from his possession, officials said. According to police, the case was registered on November 13, 2025, following a complaint from a woman resident of East Rohtash Nagar, who reported being duped through a fraudulent job offer.

The victim was asked to register via a link sent to her mobile phone. On clicking it, her phone was compromised, following which eight unauthorised transactions were carried out from her bank account, resulting in a loss of Rs 1,51,018, police said.

The complainant reported the incident on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, after which an FIR was registered. AGENCIES

Year on, Chattarpur's key Mandi Road project still in pipeline

Mehrauli-Faridabad 8.8 km stretch sees peak-hour congestion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Nearly a year after the Delhi government announced plans to hand over the widening of the crucial Mandi Road in Chattarpur to the NHAI, work on the project has yet to begin, officials said on Saturday.

The 8.8-kilometre stretch, which connects Mehrauli in south Delhi to Faridabad in Haryana, remains heavily congested during peak hours, serving as a key link for commuters travelling between Gurugram and the Chattarpur area.

In April 2025, Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh announced that the project would be handed over to the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) and that the road would be declared a national highway. However, the proposal to facilitate the handover is still awaiting approval, delaying the commencement of on-ground work. There was no response



In Short

» "Given its role in facilitating freight movement to industrial zones and connecting to national highways, the project has broader national and regional significance beyond local urban transit," an official said.

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from the PWD minister on the matter.

"Given its role in facilitating freight movement to industrial zones and connecting to national highways, the project has broader national and regional significance beyond local urban transit," an official said.

According to an initial project report, the existing road is narrow and flanked by farmhouses, residential properties and individual shops. The scale of land acquisition required prompted the Delhi government to propose transferring the project to NHAI, which is considered better equipped to

handle such processes.

"We are trying to expedite the work on widening of Mandi road. There are some trees and other issues that are being worked out," Gajinder Yadav, Chhatarpur MLA, said. Mandi Road begins near the Chattarpur metro station on MG Road and extends to Faridabad Road, crossing into Haryana. Owing to its strategic importance and rising traffic demand, authorities have proposed that the stretch be declared a national highway and linked to NH-148A.

"In view of its strategic importance, existing and future traffic demand and its direct connectivity with NH-148A, Mandi Road of total length may be considered for declaration as a national highway," the plan stated.

The road, however, continues to face heavy congestion during morning and evening rush hours, with delays in approvals and land acquisition keeping the long-pending widening project on hold.

746 challans in crackdown to decongest IIT intersection

NEW DELHI: A week-long enforcement drive at the busy IIT intersection in south Delhi saw 746 traffic challans issued, including 329 for improper parking, as authorities moved to ease chronic congestion at the arterial junction, the Delhi Traffic Police said on Saturday.

The intersection, where Outer Ring Road meets Aurobindo Marg, faces daily bottlenecks due to CNG queues, roadside parking near commercial establishments, and peak-hour school traffic, they said. "During the drive, 746 challans were issued, including 329 for improper parking, to improve compliance and ensure smoother flow of traffic," a senior traffic police officer said.

The drive, led by the traffic police along with Delhi Transport Corporation and local stakeholders, focused on clearing encroachments, enforcing lane discipline and regulating vehicle movement at key pressure points. Authorities also deployed personnel at all four arms of the intersection to prevent roadside parking, regulated queues at the CNG station. AGENCIES

Police said that the gang used to upload fake customer care numbers

was assured a refund," a senior police officer said.

The caller later reached out through social media and convinced the victim to share his phone screen and grant accessibility permissions. Soon after, the phone screen went blank, and Rs 85,000 was debited from one bank account, followed by Rs 40,000 from another, police

ARRESTED FROM UP'S JHANSI

2 pose as customer care, dupe man of over Rs 1L

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested two men from Uttar Pradesh's Jhansi for allegedly cheating a man here for Rs 1.25 lakh by posing as customer care executives of an e-commerce brand, an official said on Saturday.

"The case came to light after complainant Arvind purchased an electronic shaver online on Oct 2, 2025, and found it defective. While searching for customer care details online on Oct 4, he contacted a number that appeared genuine and

Interrogation revealed that Pankaj Yadav had provided his bank account to an associate identified as Vansh in exchange for money. He withdrew Rs 85,000, handed over around Rs 55,000 to Vansh and transferred Rs 40,000 to Satyam," the officer added.

Satyam withdrew Rs 20,000 and transferred the remaining amount to another associate, Kamal. The accused also disclosed that calls to victims were made by gang members operating from Jharkhand. MPOST

City Briefs

'AUTHORITARIAN RULE': HANSRAJ STUDENTS PROTEST FEST CURBS

NEW DELHI: Several students of Hansraj College staged a protest on Saturday, alleging arbitrary restrictions and denial of institutional support for activities by the administration. Protestors, including the elected students' union, Students' Federation of India and various societies, gathered on the campus to express their resentment over an order limiting the college fest to conclude before 6 pm. Addressing the gathering, SFI Hansraj Unit Secretary Srijan criticised the administration's approach, stating that students would continue to resist what he described as "authoritarian functioning".

DRUG SUPPLY NETWORK BUSTED IN DELHI, MEDICAL STORE OWNER HELD

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested a 26-year-old medical store owner and busted a drug supply network in the outer Delhi area, officials said on Saturday. The accused, identified as Tushar Malhotra, a resident of Motia Khan, was apprehended following a raid in Paharganj on April 2. Police said the action stemmed from a case registered at the Nihal Vihar police station on March 26, in which three persons with contraband, including codeine syrup and Buprenorphine tablets, were earlier arrested. During interrogation, one of the accused disclosed the source of supply. Acting on the lead, a joint team of police and drug inspector officials raided the medical store, seizing codeine-based cough syrup and psychotropic capsules.

RAIN & HAILSTORMS CONTINUE TO LASH NORTHERN STATES

Snow in hills, rain in plains as western disturbance sweeps north India

NEW DELHI: The higher reaches of Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir on Saturday witnessed fresh snowfall as a spell of wet weather gripped north India, bringing rainfall to parts of Delhi, Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan.

Rains and hailstorms have continued to lash the northern states intermittently this week, with wheat growers in Punjab, Haryana and Rajasthan staring at major losses due to crop damage.

The national capital, meanwhile, witnessed rain during the night between Friday and Saturday in isolated areas. However, the maximum temperature in the city dropped due to persistent cloudy conditions throughout the day.

In Jammu and Kashmir, the snowfall also led to the closure of many important inter-district roads, officials said.

The Met Office warned of brief but intense heavy showers in isolated parts, which may lead to flash floods and landslides at a few vulnerable places and waterlogging in a few low-lying areas.

Sadhna Top and other higher reaches in Kupwara, Mughal Road in Shopian, Margan Top connecting Anantnag with Kishtwar, and Razdan Top, Gurez, and Tulail in Bandipora district, received fresh overnight snowfall. The Affarwat mountain in Gulmarg tourist resort, the Sonamarg-Zojila axis, and some other hilly areas of the valley also received snowfall.

The plains of the valley,



Residents clear snow following fresh snowfall, in Sissu, Lahaul and Spiti district of Himachal Pradesh, Saturday

PTI

including the summer capital Srinagar, received rains, they added. The wet weather brought down the day temperature across the valley as people had to layer up to battle the fresh cold.

Similarly, both maximum and minimum temperatures decreased in Himachal Pradesh, with light to moderate rain and snowfall observed in several areas.

The Shimla Meteorological Office has issued an orange alert for hailstorms, thunderstorms, lightning, and gusty winds with speeds of 40 to 50 kmph in the Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi, and Shimla districts on Tuesday and Wednesday.

In the higher reaches of Lahaul and Spiti and Kullu,

fresh snowfall was witnessed over the past 24 hours since Friday evening. The weather department also predicted a wet spell in the state till April 10.

In the national capital, the minimum temperature rose to 20.7 degrees Celsius, which is 1.9 degrees above normal and 1.5 degrees higher than the previous day. In contrast, the maximum temperature reached 32 degrees Celsius, two degrees below normal and one degree lower than the day before.

Mahesh Palawat, vice president at Skymet, said, "This is due to the presence of a cloud cover, as a result of which lesser heat penetrates during the day and lesser heat escapes from the earth's surface at night." Parts of Rajasthan recorded rainfall and

gusty winds over the past 24 hours due to a cyclonic circulation with more thunderstorms and hail activity forecasted for the region in the coming days, the IMD said on Saturday.

"A new and strong western disturbance is likely to become active over parts of Jodhpur and Bikaner divisions from the afternoon of April 6, leading to a high possibility of thunderstorm and rainfall activity in some areas," the IMD said.

The impact of the cyclone is expected to peak on April 7. "Under its activity, several parts of Jodhpur, Bikaner, Ajmer, Jaipur, Bharatpur and Kota divisions are likely to experience strong thunderstorms, gusty winds of 50-60 kmph, moderate to heavy rainfall and isolated

Highlights

» In Jammu and Kashmir, the snowfall also led to the closure of many important inter-district roads, officials said

» In the higher reaches of Lahaul and Spiti and Kullu, fresh snowfall was witnessed over the past 24 hours since Friday evening

» 'A new and strong western disturbance is likely to become active over parts of Jodhpur and Bikaner divisions from the afternoon of April 6'

hailstorms," it said. "Farmers are advised to cover harvested crops and grains kept in open areas or shift them to safe storage to prevent damage due to rain and hail," the weather office said.

Former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot demanded immediate financial assistance for farmers affected by unseasonal rain and hailstorms in parts of the state, saying the damage has caused a crisis for farmers. "In some parts of the state, unseasonal rain and hailstorms have brought disaster upon farmers. Wheat and Isabgol crops have been damaged in Bikaner division, while in Nagaur, crops like isabgol, cumin, wheat and fennel have suffered heavy losses," he said.

AGENCIES

SC says authority carries accountability, restores bank manager's dismissal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has reinstated the dismissal of a bank's senior manager, underscoring that authority comes with accountability, and his position carried with it an increased degree of responsibility and integrity.

The top court noted allegations that the senior manager had connived with an officer and a gunman to misappropriate the money of customers for personal gain and steal bank records.

The apex court set aside the Delhi High Court order, which had modified the punishment of dismissal from service to compulsory retirement.

The high court had noted that for similar charges, different punishments were imposed on the co-delinquents -- the officer and the gunman -- with the senior manager having been given the most severe punishment without any difference in their roles.

However, the apex court disagreed with this reasoning.

"Quite apart, equating a branch manager of a bank with its gunman seems to us to be in outrageous defiance of logic and reason," a bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma said in its April 2 judgement. The bench delivered its verdict on an appeal filed by the bank challenging the September 2024 order of the high court. The top court noted that the disciplinary authority had imposed the penalty of dismissal from service on the senior manager.

The bench further noted that the disciplinary authority had



imposed the penalty of compulsory retirement on the gunman, while the co-delinquent officer was awarded "lowering by two stages".

"Whether the imposition of lighter punishment on the co-delinquents while imposing the punishment of 'dismissal from service' upon the respondent (senior manager) is in outright defiance of logic? We think not," the bench said.

It said that when he committed the offence, the respondent was holding the post of "senior manager in MMGS-III scale", which was obviously much higher than the two co-delinquents.

"Authority carries accountability; the higher the authority, the higher the accountability. The rank of the respondent was not merely titular; it carried with it an increased degree of responsibility and integrity."

"The role of the respondent not only necessitated personal obedience but also supervision of the actions of the subordinates," it said.

The bench said the co-delinquents, having limited powers and authority, could not have been equated with the respondent. It also said that the gravity of misconduct necessarily had to be measured with the nature of the misconduct.

Blast outside Punjab BJP office: 5 arrested part of Pak's ISI-backed module

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Five individuals, part of a module backed by Pakistan's ISI, have been arrested in connection with the blast incident outside the Punjab BJP headquarters in Chandigarh, said Punjab Director General of Police (DGP) Gaurav Yadav on Saturday.

The Counter-Intelligence wing of Punjab Police, in a joint operation with Chandigarh Police, solved the Chandigarh grenade attack case, DGP Yadav said.

Police recovered one hand grenade and one .30 bore Zigana pistol along with ammunition from their possession, the officer mentioned further.

Those arrested have been identified as Balwinder Lal alias Shami of village Majari in SBS Nagar, Jasvir Singh alias Jassi of village Bharpur in SBS Nagar, Charanjit Singh alias Channi of village Sujawalpur in SBS Nagar, Rubal Chauhan of village Thana in Shimla and Mandeep alias Abhijot Sharma of Dhuri in Sangrur.

According to DGP Yadav, preliminary investigations revealed that the module was backed by Pakistan's spy agency Inter-Services Intelligence and operated under the directions of foreign-based handlers located in Portugal and Germany. The accused were part of a structured network involving multiple operatives to execute the attack.

From Page 1

Fuel stocks intact...

households and transport sectors, while industrial and fertiliser sector allocations are being gradually increased, supported by incoming LNG cargoes.

All refineries are operating at high capacity with adequate crude inventories, and petrol pumps across the country remain fully stocked, the ministry said.

To shield consumers from rising global oil prices, the government has cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by 10 rupees per litre and imposed export levies on diesel and aviation fuel to boost domestic availability.

Meanwhile, an Indian LPG tanker carrying roughly half a day's cooking gas supply has successfully crossed the war-hit Strait of Hormuz, while another vessel from Iran has reached the port of Mangalore, signalling continued fuel inflows despite regional disruptions.

"LPG vessel Green Sanvi has safely transited the Strait of Hormuz, carrying 46,650 tonnes of LPG cargo with 25 seafarers on board," a government statement giving an update on West Asia developments said Saturday.

Green Sanvi is the seventh Indian-flagged LPG tanker to have transited the strategic waterway, which has remained effectively shut since the US and Israel launched attacks on Iran on February 28 and Tehran's sweeping retaliation.

Separately, an LPG cargo from Iran has arrived at Mangalore and is being discharged, according to the statement.

This perhaps is the first purchase of Iranian energy in seven years."LPG vessel Sea Bird carrying around 44,000 tonnes of Iranian LPG berthed at Mangalore, India on April 2 and is currently discharging," the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said in a post on X.

After the passage of Green Sanvi, 17 Indian flagged vessels remain stranded on the west side of the strait.

For a country that relies on imports from the Gulf nations to meet as much as 60 per cent of its cooking gas needs, the arrivals will help ease the worst LPG shortage it is battling in decades. India consumed 33.15 million tonnes of LPG last year, with imports accounting for about 60 per cent of demand. As much as 90 per cent of those imports came from the Middle East.

Centre: No pay...

destination of Vadinar in Gujarat to China due to payment hurdles, the ministry said, "there are no payment hurdles for Iranian crude imports".

"India imports crude oil from 40+ countries, with companies having full flexibility to source oil from different sources and geographies based on commercial considerations," it said.

"Amid Middle East supply disruptions, Indian refineries have secured their crude oil requirements, including from Iran, and there is no payment hurdle for Iranian crude imports, contrary to the rumours being circulated."

Ship-tracking firm Kpler on Friday stated that Aframax tanker Ping Shun, built in 2002 and sanctioned by the US in 2025, is now signalling Dongying in China as its destination instead of Vadinar in Gujarat, which it had indicated earlier this week.

Oil on Ping Shun would have been the first Iranian crude that India would have purchased since 2019. Indian refineries have been looking at opportunities to purchase a few cargoes of Iranian oil on water following the recent sanctions waiver by Washington.

The ministry clarified that changes in vessel destinations during transit are common in global oil trade, as bills of lading often indicate tentative discharge ports and cargoes may be rerouted mid-voyage for operational and commercial reasons.

"Claims on vessel diversion ignore how the oil trade works. Bills of Lading often carry indicative discharge ports, destinations and on-sea cargoes can change destinations mid-voyage based on trade optimisation and operational flexibility," the ministry said.

"It is reiterated that India's crude oil requirements remain fully secured for the coming months."

The ministry also said that an LPG vessel, Sea Bird, carrying about 44,000 tonnes of Iranian LPG, berthed at Mangalore on April 2 and is currently discharging cargo.

Historically, India was a major buyer of Iranian crude, importing significant volumes of Iranian light and heavy grades due to strong refinery compatibility and favourable commercial terms.

Following sanctions tightening in 2018, imports ceased in May 2019, with volumes replaced by Middle Eastern, US and other grades. At peak, Iranian crude accounted for 11.5 per cent of India's total imports.

India used to buy 5,18,000 barrels per day of Iranian oil in 2018, which slowed to 2,68,000 bpd between January and May 2019 when the US granted waivers to a few buyers. There have been no imports since.

The key grades that Indian refineries used to purchase are Iran light and Iran heavy crudes.

The US last month waived sanctions on the purchase of Iranian oil at sea for 30 days in its latest attempt to ease oil prices that have been driven up by the US-Israeli war on Iran.

That window expires April 19. An estimated 95 million barrels of Iranian oil are on vessels at sea, of which around 51 million barrels could be sold to India, and the remaining are better suited for buyers in China and Southeast Asia. Ping Shun is estimated to be carrying about 6,00,000 barrels of oil that was loaded from Kharg Island around March 4. Its declared ETA to Vadinar was April 4, according to Kpler.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

War: Double crash...

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Saturday reiterated his government's willingness to restart talks in Pakistan, but said they seek a "conclusive and lasting" end of the conflict.

Araghchi said he spoke by phone Friday with Turkey's foreign minister to discuss the latest developments.

Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni visited Qatar and pledged to help restoring gas infrastructure. She assured Qatar's leader during a visit Saturday that Italy would contribute to restoring Qatari energy infrastructure damaged by Iranian bombing, noting its natural gas production is critical to global energy security, her office said in a note.

Meloni is the first EU, G20 and NATO leader to visit the Gulf region since the start of the US-Israel war on Iran. She began her two-day visit Friday in Saudi Arabia and is also scheduled to visit the United Arab Emirates. The start of the visit was unannounced due to security concerns.

Austrian Foreign Minister Beate Meinl-

Reisinger said she underscored to her Iranian counterpart Abbas Araghchi "the need to halt the strikes on neighbouring countries and restore freedom of navigation in the Strait Hormuz."

The United Arab Emirates said Saturday its air defense systems engaged 23 ballistic missiles and 56 drones from Iran.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi posted on social media on Saturday that radioactive fallout from continued attacks on the Bushehr nuclear power plant "will end life" in regional capitals, not Tehran.

He accused Western governments of remaining silent about the repeated attacks on the plant. The fourth attack on the Bushehr complex occurred Saturday, killing a security guard and damaging a support building. No increase in radiation levels was reported, according to the International Atomic Energy Agency.

Bushehr is located some 750 kilometres south of Iran's capital, Tehran.

The facility uses low-enriched uranium from Russia, along with Russian technicians, to supply about 1,000 megawatts of power for Iran.

Bahrain's Defence Ministry reported the tally in a social media post on Saturday.

This brings the total number of projectiles fired at the country since the start of the war to 188 missiles and 453 drones.

US and Israeli warplanes continued to pound Iran Saturday, hitting several targets including a petrochemical facility, Iranian media reported.

Iran's official English-language newspaper Tehran Times reported that an airstrike hit a facility belonging to Iran's Agriculture Ministry in the western city of Mehran.

The newspaper said another air raid struck Mahshahr Special Petrochemical Zone in the southwestern Khuzestan province.

The Israeli military said on Saturday that its air force struck ballistic and anti-aircraft missile storage sites in Tehran.

It said the strikes a day earlier included weapons manufacture sites as well as military research and development facilities in the Iranian capital.

It said the strikes are part of an ongoing phase to increase damage to Iran's "core systems and foundations".

Authorities in Dubai said the facades of two buildings were damaged by debris from intercepted drones, including one belonging to US tech firm Oracle. No injuries were reported.

Iran's Revolutionary Guard has threatened to attack Oracle and 17 other US companies after accusing them of being involved in "terrorist espionage" operations in Iran. Previous Iranian drone strikes caused damage to three Amazon Web Services facilities in the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain. More than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran since the war began.

Open well claims...

and that the government will provide assistance of Rs 5 lakh to the kin of the deceased persons.

The Nashik collector has been asked to probe the incident and submit an inquiry report, he said.

Speaking to reporters in Nagpur, Fadnavis termed the accident "extremely unfortunate".

Preliminary information indicated that the well had a low boundary wall and was in the middle of a frequently accessed area, he said.

The state government has announced financial assistance for the affected family, he said, adding that instructions have been issued to identify and review all wells situated on roads or in areas with public movement.

"Such locations must be audited to assess

whether these wells are necessary and what safety measures can be implemented," he said, noting that a higher protective wall could have prevented the tragedy.

Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde termed the accident as heart-wrenching and painful.

No PNG...

operations can apply to the additional commissioner of the department, explaining their needs. A decision on such requests will be taken in consultation with the three OMCs.

"The OMCs could also collect such applications and submit to the Additional Commissioner for a prompt decision. The Additional Commissioner shall promptly dispose of the same in consultation with the three Oil Marketing Companies," the order stated.

The rest of the policy, notified on March 26 along with a subsequent addendum, will remain unchanged, the order said.

India resilient...

Even many developed societies have not done so," the EAM said.

Jaishankar stressed that there is no getting away from building robust national capabilities, which he noted is the most effective way to de-risk and develop leverage.

"Building national capabilities has become more critical in the light of the global trends that I have mentioned. This is particularly so for large nations. You would note that even in the developed world, the earlier mantras of globalisation have now given way to a new awareness about self-reliance," he pointed out.

In India, this is expressed as 'Atmanirbhar Bharat', the value of which is obvious when it comes to food, health, energy security or national security, he said.

"We must endeavour to secure within our control as many capacities as we can. Obviously, some domains will be more difficult than others. In such cases, the answers lie in reliable or trusted partnerships and diverse sourcing. Building robust national capabilities is the most effective way of de-risking and indeed even developing leverage," Jaishankar said.

The global order is changing with visible shifts in relative power and influence of countries, and the turbulence in the world is currently structural in many ways, he opined.

"The politics of some societies find it difficult to come to terms with these changes. New developments in technology, energy, military capabilities, connectivity, and resources have encouraged risk-taking in an increasingly competitive environment. Everything today is being leveraged, if not actually weaponised," he said.

The world is then confronted with the prospect of securing itself in an increasingly volatile and unpredictable environment, which has necessitated a larger inclination to hedge, to de-risk, and to diversify, whether it is a business choice or a foreign policy one, the external affairs minister said.

Asserting that nation-building is an extremely complex task with many dimensions, he highlighted the role of business and enterprise.

"A cross-cutting aspect is the strength and dynamism of our businesses. You will note that in our endeavour to catch up for the lost decades of the past, a crucial initiative is now making it easier to do business. Even that is possible when the enabling environment is more positive," he said.

There has been significant improvements in ease of living and access to opportunities, particularly for entrepreneurs, startups and small businesses, while the expansion of educational institutions and increased focus on skill development have further strengthened India's human capital, he added.

Referring to the triple challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic, ongoing global conflicts, and climate change as the disruptions of the decade, he said the growing frequency of extreme climate events and the steady erosion of natural habitats pose both short-term and long-term concerns.

Jaishankar said the graduating class at the event must count itself as fortunate because it is destined to achieve the goal of 'Viksit Bharat'.

"You are the beneficiaries of a solid decade of progress. You have gained from access to technology and to information that would have been inconceivable barely a generation ago. Today, India is poised to leapfrog in its journey of development, and your cohort will be amongst those that will lead this effort," he said.

Outlining the evolving role of India's foreign policy, Jaishankar said it is increasingly focused on expanding market access for Indian producers, securing critical resources and technologies, and supporting Indian citizens abroad, especially during times of crisis.

It promotes "Brand India" globally, essential to the perception of the country as a reliable and trusted partner, he added.

Census 2027: MoS Nityanand Rai, PS to PM P K Mishra self-enumerate

NEW DELHI: Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai and Principal Secretary to Prime Minister P K Mishra participated in the Census 2027 exercise on Saturday by self-enumerating on the special portal launched by the Registrar General of India (RGI) for the maiden initiative.

In a post on X, Rai said the process will further accelerate India's development under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's inspiring leadership and play an important role in effectively delivering government schemes to every citizen of the country.

"Under the guidance of the Honourable Home Minister Shri Amit Shah Ji, the Census has for the first time been initiated in digital form as well, which is making it simpler and more effective. You too can go to its official portal se.census.gov.in and perform your own self-enumeration according to your area," Rai said.

He urged people to provide the necessary information when enumerators come to their residence. Mishra also completed the self-enumeration process for the first phase (the housing and housing census) on Saturday.

"We express our sincere gratitude to Shri P K Mishra ji for his active participation and support in this monumental national exercise. The digital self-enumeration facility makes the process convenient, quick, and accessible to everyone," the RGI said in a post on X.

By completing self-enumeration, residents contribute directly to reliable census data that supports inclusive development and effective governance, it added.

AGENCIES

POLLS TO 140 ASSEMBLY SEATS TO BE HELD ON APRIL 9

Modi targets LDF, UDF in Kerala; courts Christian voters before polls

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THIRUVALLA: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday intensified the NDA's campaign for the Kerala Assembly polls, sharpening his attack on the LDF and UDF over issues including the FCRA and the Sabarimala gold loss matter, and likening their rivalry to a "WWF fight".

At a BJP-led alliance's rally here in the Pathanamthitta district, Modi sought to reach out to the Christian community, a key voting bloc in the state, which his party has long tried to attract but struggled amid attacks on Christians in north Indian states and concerns over proposed FCRA amendments.

He claimed that the count-down for the removal of the CPI(M)-led LDF government in Kerala has started, and a BJP-led NDA will come to power in the state. Elections to 140 Assembly seats will be held on April 9 in the state.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi being felicitated during a public meeting ahead of the Kerala Assembly elections, in Thiruvalla, Kerala

"In the Northeast, with a significant Christian population, the NDA has formed governments in six states. We have delivered on work that was pending for decades. In Goa too, with a sizeable Christian community, we continue to serve and drive development," Modi said,

in a bid to woo the community to the NDA fold ahead of the crucial polls.

Hitting back at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, who alleged that the Prime Minister remained silent on the Sabarimala issue during his Kerala visit, indicating that the BJP

Highlights

- » Modi claimed that the countdown for the removal of the CPI(M)-led LDF government in Kerala has started
- » Modi said the LDF has not handed over to the CBI the probe into the gold loss matter, raising serious questions
- » Modi claimed that there is a clear pattern in the "loot" at the Lord Ayyappa shrine

probe into the gold loss matter, raising serious questions.

"At the same time, Congress, which has largely stayed away from temple-related issues, is now faking, trying to project itself as pro-Hindu. Once an NDA government is formed, a thorough investigation into both LDF and UDF will be conducted, and those found guilty will be punished. Devotees of Swami Ayyappa expect nothing less than justice," he said.

He also said that the corruption and appeasement politics of the Left and Congress are directly impacting Kerala's culture and faith.

"First, they defamed the Sabarimala temple. Today, it is being looted by them," the prime minister said.

Modi also accused the LDF and UDF of repeatedly misleading people, saying they had dismissed films such as "Kerala Files", "Kashmir Files" and "Dhurandhar" as false.

‘Minorities facing widespread attacks in different parts of nation’

Rahul raises the alleged attacks on minorities in Manipur and Chhattisgarh during Kerala election rallies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

ALAPPUZHA/IDUKKI/ KOCHI: Top Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday raised the alleged attacks on minorities in Manipur and Chhattisgarh during his election campaign in central Kerala districts, and claimed that Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan was aligned with forces behind such incidents.

Gandhi alleged that minorities were facing widespread attacks in different parts of the country.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha addressed multiple election rallies in Alappuzha, Kattappana in Idukki district, and Fort Kochi and Kunnathunad in Ernakulam district ahead of the April 9 Assembly election.

His remarks on attacks on minorities come amid concerns expressed by sections of the Christian community over proposed amendments to the Foreign Contribution (Regu-



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi addresses a public meeting at Kattappana

lation) Act (FCRA), which seek stricter monitoring of foreign funds.

In Alappuzha, former CPI(M) leader G Sudhakaran, contesting as a UDF-backed candidate, was also present on the stage.

"Two nuns from here were attacked in Chhattisgarh. In Manipur, churches were burnt. The chief minister has a partnership with the people who are doing this. The very people who are attacking minori-

ties—Muslims, Christians and Sikhs—have a partnership with the CM," he alleged, adding that the BJP and LDF has a nexus in the polls to defeat the UDF.

He repeated similar allegations at other campaign venues.

In Kochi, Gandhi said the LDF was no longer a Left formation but a partner of a political force that attacks people because of their faith—whether they are Christians, Muslims, Sikhs or Jains.

"How can the chief minister stand with them? How can he not be ashamed after his Left training? He is aligned with this force," the Congress leader said, adding that Vijayan must answer to the people of Kerala.

He also directly targeted Vijayan, alleging that the CM was "afraid" of Prime Minister Narendra Modi in order to protect his children. Rahul made an apparent reference to the Exalogic case allegedly involving the CM's daughter, without naming anyone.

‘Raghav failed to raise Punjab’s issues in Parl, his silence disappointing’

‘... Ghatak hoon’: Raghav Chadha vows to unmask AAP’s ‘lies’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The AAP on Saturday criticised Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha for allegedly failing to raise key issues concerning Punjab in Parliament and said that his "inaction" was contrary to the party's principles.

In a joint statement, Punjab Finance Minister Harpal Singh Cheema, state AAP president Aman Arora and party leader Kuldeep Singh Dhaliwal said that Chadha's silence on several critical matters was "disappointing".

Cheema said Chadha, who was elected to the Rajya Sabha by Punjab MLAs, was expected to strongly represent the state's concerns at the national level, but did not raise "even a single sensitive issue" related to it.

Key financial concerns, including around Rs 8,500 crore in pending Rural Development Fund (RDF) dues and GST-related losses worth nearly Rs 60,000 crore, were not highlighted in Parliament, the minister said.

He also listed financial setbacks due to changes in GST compensation and issues related to funding under the National Health Mission among the matters that the MP allegedly failed to raise.

Punjab has not received the full financial assistance of Rs 1,600 crore announced by Prime Minister Narendra Modi after last year's floods in the state. This matter was



AAP MP Raghav Chadha

also not raised in Parliament, Cheema said.

Terming Chadha's silence "disappointing", the minister said the AAP had expected the MP to take up these issues with the Centre and that his "inaction" was contrary to the party's principles.

The spat between the Aam Aadmi Party and its Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha intensified on Saturday with the sidelined leader dismissing AAP's allegation against him as "lies" and asserting that he went to Parliament to raise people's issues and not to create ruckus.

"All these lies will be unmasked. Kyunki mai ghayal hoon, isiliye ghatak hoon" (I am wounded, therefore I am dangerous)," the MP said in a video statement, quoting from the movie 'Dhurandhar', and alleged that there was a "scripted, coordinated" attack against him.

Editors Guild calls on govt to review draft rules of IT Second Amendment Rules

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Editors Guild of India has expressed its deep concern over both the contents and the underlying intent behind the Draft Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Second Amendment Rules, 2026 ("Draft Amendments"), which were made public by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on March 30, with just a fortnight given for comments.

The EGi called on the government to urgently review or recall the draft rules, and engage in more constructive consultations with all sections of stakeholders and take on board valid concerns and objections

"Prima facie, the amended

rules and guidelines, whose stated purpose is to "strengthen compliance" and increase the effectiveness of regulatory oversight of content regulation mechanisms under Part III (Code of Ethics relating to Digital Media) of the IT Rules, 2021" appear to arm MeitY with sweeping powers of content regulation, sharply increases the compliance burden on digital intermediaries, and gives the executive overarching powers to block or take down content generated by "non news publishers" and intermediaries.

This will directly infringe the fundamental right to free speech guaranteed to all citizens under the Constitution and will have a chilling effect on freedom of expression and the airing of contrarian views, which are fundamental to an open and functional democ-

racy," the Guild said in a statement on Saturday.

Further, the Guild pointed out, sub-rule (4) to Rule 3, which deals with due diligence obligations of intermediaries, now makes it mandatory on the part of intermediaries to comply with "any clarification, advisory, order, direction, standard operating procedure, code of practice or guideline issued by the ministry, by order in writing".

The Guild said that failure to comply has been linked to loss of the safe harbour protection extended to intermediaries and platforms for user-generated content, under section 79 of the Information Technology Act.

The absence of due process for the issuance of compliance orders and the complete lack of transparency in the process are deeply concerning.

"Changes to Rule 14(2) and Rule 14(5) in the draft amendment also greatly widen the powers of the Inter-Departmental Committee (IDC). IDC, a central oversight body constituted under Rule 14 of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, was specifically created to hear grievances and complaints against digital content.

Now, the IDC has been empowered to deal with and "matter" – a generalisation which arms the body to consider virtually any issue, in the absence of any definition of what constitutes a "matter". Other provisions devolve rulemaking powers entirely to the executive branch, removing the window for legislative oversight provided under the IT Act," it said.

UP: Three men die after consuming spurious liquor

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

MEERUT: Three men died in Daurala area of Meerut on Friday night after allegedly consuming spurious liquor, triggering panic in the locality and a swift crackdown by the administration.

Family members of the deceased have alleged that the liquor consumed by the victims was poisonous. Acting on the complaint, the district administration sealed the country liquor shop from where the alcohol was purchased and ordered an inquiry into the incident.

Police said the liquor vend is registered in the name of Jaipal Ahlawat, father of BKU leader Mintu Ahlawat.

Jaipal Ahlawat and two salesmen from the shop have been taken into custody for questioning.

According to police, the deceased have been identified as Baburam Prajapati, 55, a native of Bharala village who worked in mustard processing and was currently staying in Daurala, and his acquaintances Ankrit, 45, and Jitendra, 50, both residents of Daurala.

The three had purchased country liquor from a shop on Sardhana Road and consumed it together.

Soon after consuming the liquor, their condition deteriorated. Baburam's son Sachin said they were rushed to a private hospital near the toll plaza. Doctors declared Ankrit and Jitendra dead on arrival, while Baburam succumbed during treatment about an hour later.

The SSP said the exact cause of death would be established only after the postmortem report is received.

‘MOVE WILL REDUCE QUEUES, MAKE POLLING PROCESS FASTER...’

ECI clears 4,660 auxiliary booths, nod to relocate 321 to ease voting

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Election Commission of India (ECI) has approved the creation of 4,660 new auxiliary polling stations, while also clearing the relocation of 321 polling stations to improve voter convenience.

According to Commission sources, auxiliary polling stations will be set up alongside booths where the number of voters exceeds 1,200, in order to reduce crowding and ensure smoother voting operations. With this addition, the total number of polling stations across the 294

Bengal Polls

- » The total number of polling stations across the 294 Assembly constituencies in West Bengal will increase from 80,681 to 85,379
- » The ECI has directed that all polling stations should be equipped with Assured Minimum Facilities

Assembly constituencies in West Bengal will increase from 80,681 to 85,379.

"We expect that this move will significantly reduce queues and make the polling process faster and more transparent on election day," said a senior ECI official.

In Bengal, the election is scheduled to be held in two phases on April 23 and 29.

Apart from adding new booths, the ECI has also decided to relocate 321 polling stations to different parts of the state. In many cases, the earlier locations were found to be inconvenient or

lacked adequate infrastructure, prompting the Commission to approve their relocation.

The apex poll body, however, has laid down strict conditions for both the creation of auxiliary booths and the relocation of existing polling stations.

According to the Commission, all auxiliary polling stations must be established strictly in accordance with the ECI's existing guidelines, with no deviation from the prescribed rules under any circumstances. In every case, where a polling station is shifted, it will be mandatory to inform each affected voter individually,

so that no confusion arises on polling day. The responsibility of this communication will rest with the local administration.

The Commission has directed wide publicity regarding the setting up of auxiliary booths as well as the relocation of polling stations. Recognised political parties must also be informed in writing about these changes.

In addition, officials at every administrative level have been asked to remain fully updated on the new arrangements.

The ECI has directed that all polling stations should be equipped with Assured Mini-

mum Facilities (AMFs), including drinking water, shaded waiting areas, toilets, proper lighting, ramps for persons with disabilities, and clear signage. Voter assistance booths will also be established to help electors locate their polling stations and verify their details on the electoral rolls.

For the first time in Assembly polls, there should be arrangements for depositing mobile phones outside polling stations. There will be seating provisions, particularly for the aged electors, to enhance the overall voting experience.

Spread lies, mislead people, Oppn’s only agenda, alleges Haryana CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini targeted the Opposition, stating that it neither has a clear policy nor any vision.

He said the Opposition has only one agenda—to spread confusion, tell lies, and mislead the public.

"When real development takes place, those indulging in politics of falsehoods feel uncomfortable," he said.

He added that Opposition leaders only enjoyed power, promoted dynastic politics, and trapped people in a web of promises. "Today, the public is aware and firmly stands with the government on the issue of development, and therefore the Opposition's lies and misinformation will not succeed," he added.

The Chief Minister was addressing a Dhanyawad evam Vikas Rally in Safidon, Jind, on Saturday. Earlier, he inaugurated and laid the foundation stone of 10 development projects worth ₹49.73 crore.

These included the inauguration of 6 projects worth ₹19.31 crore and the foundation laying of 4 projects worth



Nayab Singh Saini

₹30.42 crore.

Saini said that the land of Safidon is known for agriculture as well as struggle and self-respect.

He remarked that there was a time when people here had to struggle even for basic amenities. Roads were in poor condition, and people had to depend on influential individuals for employment. Development was limited to paper.

"But today, the situation has completely changed. The positive transformation seen in the state and the country is the result of strong and visionary leadership," he added.

Praising the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, he said that the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 has given new energy and direction to the

nation. He said that the Haryana government is working on the principle of "Nation First" and stands firmly with the people in every crisis.

He assured citizens that there is no shortage of petrol, diesel, or domestic cooking gas in the state and that adequate stock is available at all petrol pumps and gas agencies.

He said that Opposition leaders are spreading confusion through cheap politics during this global crisis and appealed to people not to pay attention to rumours.

He said strict measures have been taken to curb black marketing and several FIRs have already been registered. Additionally, to promote expansion of gas pipelines, lease rent has been reduced from ₹3 lakh to ₹1,000, which will help accelerate the target of providing PNG connections to lakhs of households.

The Chief Minister said that earlier, people in Safidon region had to struggle for basic facilities, but now the situation has completely transformed. Concrete roads in villages, better irrigation facilities, and transparent employment opportunities for youth are now available.

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EC PUBLISHES 10TH ADJUDICATION LIST

Bengal CEO starts field visits; nearly 57L adjudication cases disposed

SOUMITRA NANDI

KOLKATA: Bengal Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Manoj Agarwal on Saturday started field visits to review poll preparedness and security arrangements on the ground.

Agarwal reached East Midnapore on Saturday late afternoon and held some important meetings to assess preparedness for the polls.

He will be staying in the district on Sunday and will hold some meetings with all concerned officials associated with the polls.

He is also scheduled to inspect administrative offices and verify if security measures are being implemented in accordance with the Commission's guidelines.

As of Friday, nearly 57 lakh cases have been disposed of out of the total 60 lakh electors under adjudication by the roughly 700 judicial officers handling the process.

The Commission, on Saturday, published the 10th adjudication list. According to Commission sources, nearly 45 per cent of the adjudicated cases so far have been deleted.

Although the tribunal

Bengal Polls

- » Although the tribunal appeal process for aggrieved electors began nearly a week ago, the Commission has not yet announced any specific dates for its official commencement
- » As per the Commission, all Central government and central PSU employees should be appointed as presiding officer and polling personnel as per their seniority, rank and pay scale
- » 'The majority of the documents submitted at its office over the past few days are not Form-6 applications'
- » The Commission has issued strict instructions against roping in any contractual employee for elections

appeal process for aggrieved electors began nearly a week ago, the Commission has not yet announced any specific dates for its official commencement.

The Commission on Saturday issued a series of instructions for the district electoral officers (DEOs) for smooth management of the manpower database and tackling the shortfall of election staff, if any, during the elections.

The poll body has directed the DEO's to make advance planning to engage manpower from neighbouring states, if required. For this purpose, they have been asked to create a surplus database.

The Commission has issued strict instructions against roping in any contractual employee for elections. Separate lists should be prepared for central and state employees who are being engaged for the polls, as per the Commission's directions.

As per the Commission, all Central government and central PSU employees should be appointed as presiding officer and polling personnel as per their seniority, rank and pay scale.

There is no need to keep any micro observers at the district level. The poll body has further directed for engaging an opti-

mum number of women polling parties and the requirement of women central forces to be assessed accordingly.

The poll body, for the first time, is making arrangements for depositing mobile phones of the voters at the polling booth. The Booth Level Officers should be engaged at the polling station for facilitating the deposit of mobiles at the polling venues.

Instructions have been issued to strictly adhere to the principle of 'seniority' within polling parties. The state CEO has further directed the DEOs to limit staff exemptions solely to cases of extreme urgency.

The state Home department has come out with good news for election officials. If anyone falls ill or meets with an accident while performing their duties, they will receive free medical treatment. The state will bear all associated costs.

Meanwhile, in a statement on its X handle, the CEO's office claimed that over the past few days, a good number of documents and letters have been submitted, and the majority of those are application forms pertaining to appeals by voters marked as 'deleted' in the final

roll published on February 28.

The state CEO's office, in a statement, clarified that the majority of the documents submitted at its office over the past few days are not Form-6 applications. Rather, these submissions primarily consist of applications or appeals filed by voters whose names were marked as 'deleted' or excluded in the final electoral roll published on February 28, 2024.

It was further stated that, in accordance with the Representation of the People Act, 1950, such applications may be submitted to the District Magistrate or the Chief Electoral Officer. The CEO's office completely denied submission of Form 6 applications and said that "the claim is being deliberately circulated".

A Trinamool delegation that visited the CEO's office on Friday had claimed that the CEO admitted receipt of Form 6 applications and would display district-wise Form 6 applications of voters who had been deleted in February.

Polling for all 294 Assembly constituencies in West Bengal will be held in two phases on April 23 and April 29, with counting scheduled for May 4.

Name Change

I, Amit Sahu S/o Sh. Sanjay Kumar R/o H.No. 2776, Gali No. 2 Saran School Road Jawahar Colony, Faridabad Sector-22, Faridabad, Haryana do hereby solemnly & declare That in all my documents my name mention is Amit Sahu but in my HDFC LIFE POLICY No. 01436647 my name mention is Amit Kumar. my real name is Amit Sahu. That Amit Sahu & Amit Kumar both name are belong to same & one person.

COURT NOTICE
(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)
IN THE COURT OF
Sh. Jogender Singh
Civil Judge (Senior Division) Bhiwani
Raj Dulari
Vs.
General Public
CNR No. . HRBH02-000620-2026
CIS NO. GW/05/2026
Next Date 02-05-2026
PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
General Public
:-
India
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on **02-05-2026 at 10:00 am.** For details login to https://highcourtchd.gov.in/?2mod=district_notice&district=Bhiwani Sd/- Sh. Jogender Singh Civil Judge (Senior Division) Dated 04.04.2026 Bhiwani

IDBI BANK LIMITED

DEMAND NOTICE – SECTION 13(2) OF SARFAESI ACT.

SPEED POST WITH AD.

Ref. No. IDBI Bank/RR/Delhi- NCR

Date: 28.01.2026

Sh. Ashutosh Kumar (Borrower)

Flat No. E-302, 3rd Floor, Cloud 9 Ahinsha Khand -2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, U.P.- 201014
Ph. #9771492880

Sh. Ashutosh Kumar (Borrower)

S/o Sh. Ranjeet Kumar Verma, Flat No D 4/4 A, Sail City, New Pundag, Dhruwa, Ranchi, Jharkhand 834004

Sh. Ashutosh Kumar (Borrower)

Mirka India Pvt.Ltd.373, 1st Floor, Patpargunj Industrial Area, New Delhi- 110092

Sh. Ashutosh Kumar (Borrower)

Flat No.F-302, 3rd Floor, Tower-F, Express Astra Sector- 1, Greater Noida West-201301

Mrs. Vinita Kumari (Co-Borrower)

Flat No. E-302, 3rd Floor, Cloud 9, Ahinsha Khand-2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, U.P.- 201014

Mrs. Vinita Kumari (Co-Borrower)

Flat No.-F-302, 3rd Floor, Tower-F, Express Astra Sector- 1, Greater Noida West 20130

Dear Sir/ Ma'am,

Financial assistance sanctioned to you by IDBI Bank Limited – (HL Account Number: 0200675100094160 and 0200675100094179)
Defaults committed - Statutory notice under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of the Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002

1. We, IDBI Bank Limited ("IDBI Bank"), through the Authorized Officer, do hereby issue this statutory notice to you, under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of the Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 ("the Act") in the circumstances narrated below:

2. IDBI Bank, granted financial assistance to you, Mr. Ashutosh Kumar ("Borrower") and Mrs. Vinita Kumari ("Co-Borrower") in the form of Home Loan of Rs. 45,70,000 (Rupees Forty Five Lakh Seventy Thousand Only) and Loan Insurance of Rs 66890.00 (Rupees Sixty Six Thousand Eight Hundred Ninety Only) against the mortgage of property (collectively "the Financial Assistance") on the terms and conditions contained in the Loan Agreement dated 17/02/2022 ("the Loan Agreement") and the security documents including the guarantee(s) if any and other securities ("the Security Documents"), the particulars whereof are given in Annexure 1A.

3. As security for the Financial Assistance, you, have created security interest in favor of IDBI Bank, in respect of immovable property i.e., All that piece and parcel of Immovable property consisting of Flat No. F-302, 3rd Floor, Tower-F, Express Astra Sector- 1, Greater Noida West-201301. The above immovable property are hereinafter collectively referred to as "the Secured Assets", particulars whereof are given in Annexure – 1B.

4. Pursuant to the above, you, Mr. Ashutosh Kumar and Mrs. Vinita Kumari have availed the disbursement aggregating Rs.38,34,277/- (Rupees Thirty Eight Lakh Thirty Four Thousand Two Hundred Seventy Seven Only) from time to time.

5. In terms of the Loan Agreement read with the Security Documents, you, Mr. Ashutosh Kumar and Mrs. Vinita Kumari have agreed to repay to IDBI Bank, the Financial Assistance in accordance with the amortization schedule contained in the Loan Agreement. You, Mr. Ashutosh Kumar and Mrs. Vinita Kumari, have failed and neglected to pay to IDBI Bank, the installments of principal amount of the Financial Assistance, interest and other monies, the particulars whereof are given in Annexure II. Consequent upon the defaults committed by you, Mr. Ashutosh Kumar and Mrs. Vinita Kumari, the account(s) in respect of the Financial Assistance, has/have been classified by IDBI Bank as Non Performing Asset (NPA) on 09-12-2025 in accordance with the directions/ extant guidelines issued by the Reserve Bank of India from time to time.

6. In view of the defaults committed by you Mr. Ashutosh Kumar and Mrs. Vinita Kumari, IDBI Bank issued Loan Recall Notice dated 16.01.2026, and has declared the Financial Assistance together with interest and other moneys aggregating Rs. 3697270/- (Rupees Thirty Six Lakhs Ninety Seven Thousand Two Hundred and Seventy Only) as on 09/12/2025 to have become immediately due and payable by you, and called upon you, Mr. Ashutosh Kumar and Mrs. Vinita Kumari, to pay to IDBI Bank the said amount. A copy of the said letter is enclosed hereto for your ready reference. The particulars of outstanding amount as on 09/12/2025 are given in Annexure III.

7. In the premises, IDBI Bank has become entitled to and does issue this statutory notice to you under Section 13 (2) of the Act and hereby calls upon you to pay to IDBI Bank at Retail Recovery Department, 8th Floor, Plate B, NBCC Building, East Kidiwai Nagar Delhi 110023, within a period of 60 days from the date of this notice, the aforesaid sum aggregating Rs. 3697270/- (Rupees Thirty Six Lakhs Ninty Seven Thousand Two Hundred and Seventy Only) as on 09/12/2025 as per Annexure - II, together with further interest thereon with effect from 10/12/2025 to IDBI Bank, at the contractual rates upon the footing of compound interest, until payment/realisation, failing which IDBI Bank, as a secured creditor shall be entitled to enforce its security interest without intervention of the Court or Tribunal, by taking recourse to one or more of the measures under Chapter III of the Act, including (but not limited to) taking over of possession and/or management of the Secured Assets, short particulars whereof are given in Annexure-IB for realising its dues at your own risk as to the costs and consequences thereof.

8. We also invite your attention to provisions of sub section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in accordance of which if the Borrower does not tender the outstanding sum together with all costs, charges and expenses incurred by secured creditor, at any time before the date of publication of notice for public auction or inviting quotation or tender from public or private treaty, the Borrower will not be entitled to redeem the secured assets.

9. Please note that after receipt of this notice, in terms of Section 13(1)(b) of the Act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise (other than in the ordinary course of your business) any of the Secured Assets described in Annexure-IB hereto, without prior written consent of IDBI Bank. Please note that contravention of the provisions of the Act is an offence punishable under section 29 of the Act.

10. Please further note that this statutory notice is issued without prejudice to all the other rights and remedies available to IDBI Bank in law or in contract or both, in respect of the Financial Assistance.

Yours faithfully,

Authorised Officer
IDBI Bank Limited

ANNEXURE- IA

Particulars of the Financial Assistance, Amounts Disbursed And Documents Executed

Amount of Loan	Particulars of the Loan Agreements and Security Documents
Housing Loan 0200675100094160 Rs. 3767387	• Housing Loan Agreement dt 17.02.2022 • Allotment letter dt. 02.02.2022 • Permission to Mortgage dated 03.02.2022 • Tripartite Agreement Dt 03.02.2022
Loan Insurance 0200675100094179 Rs. 66890	• Loan Insurance Document

ANNEXURE – I B

Particulars of the Secured Assets intended to be enforced

The Mortgaged Assets

A mortgage of the property is as follows:

Property Detail :	Flat No. F-302, 3 rd Floor, Tower-F, Express Astra Sector- 1, Greater Noida West - 201301
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ANNEXURE- II

Particulars of the Defaults in repayment of principal and payment of interest etc. as on 09.12.2025 Defaults (Amount in Rupees)

(Amt in Rs)

Financial Assistance	Total Overdue	Principal Overdue Amount (Rs.)	Interests and Penal Interest Overdue Amount (Rs.)
Housing Loan	3668412.00	3556278.00	112134.00
Loan Insurance	28858.00	27991.00	867.00

ANNEXURE - III

Particulars of the Total Claim (as on 09.12.2025)

A

(Amt in Rs)

(PARTICULARS OF THE OUTSTANDING AMOUNTS IN RESPECT OF THE LOANS)

(Amount in Rs.)

Outstanding as on 09.12.2025	Principal	Interest and Penal Interest
Housing Loan Rs. 36,68,412/- Insurance Loan Rs. 28,858/-	Rs. 35,56,278/- Rs. 27,991/-	Rs. 1,12,134/- Rs. 867/-
Net Total claim Rs. 36,97,270/- as on 09.12.2025		

B

Particulars of Expenses

Total- Rs. 0/-

Grand Total (A+B): Rs. 36,97,270/- as on 09.12.2025

Net Total claim Rs 36,97,270/- as on 09.12.2025

'WEAK BUT STILL LETHAL'

US warplanes hit in Iran are 1st shot down by enemy fire in over 20 years

WASHINGTON: Iran shooting down two American military aircraft marks an exceedingly rare assault for the US that has not happened in more than 20 years and shows the Islamic Republic's continued ability to hit back despite President Donald Trump asserting it has been "completely decimated."

The attacks came five weeks after US and Israeli strikes first pounded Iran, with Trump saying earlier this week that Tehran's "ability to launch missiles and drones is dramatically curtailed."

Iran shot down a US F15-E Strike Eagle fighter jet Friday, with one service member getting rescued and the search still underway for a second, US officials say. Iranian state media also said a US A-10 attack aircraft crashed after being hit by Iranian defence forces.



FILE PIC

The last time a US fighter jet was shot down in combat was an A-10 Thunderbolt II during the 2003 US invasion of Iraq, said retired Air Force Brig. Gen. Houston Cantwell, a former F-16 fighter pilot.

But, he said, that's because the US had largely been fighting insurgents who didn't have the same anti-aircraft capabilities. The fact that there have not been more fighter jets lost

in Iran, Cantwell said, is a testament to the capabilities of US forces.

"The fact that this hasn't happened until now is an absolute miracle," said Cantwell, who served four combat tours and is now a senior resident fellow at the Mitchell Institute for Aerospace Studies.

"We're flying combat missions here, they are being shot at every day."

HIGHLIGHTS

» Iran shot down a US F15-E Strike Eagle fighter jet, with 1 service member getting rescued and the search still underway for a second

» Also, a US A-10 attack aircraft 'crashed after being hit by Iranian defence forces'

US Central Command said in a statement Wednesday that American forces have flown more than 13,000 missions in the Iran war while striking more than 12,300 targets.

After more than a month of punishing US-Israeli airstrikes, a degraded Iranian military nonetheless remains a stubborn foe. Its steady stream of strikes against Israel and Gulf Arab neighbours have been

causing regional upheaval and global economic shock.

When it comes to American dominance over Iran's airspace, there's still a distinction between air superiority and air supremacy, said Behnam Ben Taleblu, Iran program senior director at the Foundation for Defense of Democracies, a hawkish Washington think tank. "A disabled air defence system is not a destroyed air defence system," he said. "We shouldn't be shocked that they're still fighting."

American planes have been flying missions at lower altitudes, which makes them more vulnerable to Iran's missiles, Taleblu said. It's possible that Iran fired at the F-15 with a surface-to-air missile, but it's more likely that a portable, shoulder-fired missile was used, he said. Those are much harder to detect and reflect how Iran is "weak but still lethal." AGENCIES

Floods and landslides leave 77 dead in Afghanistan in 10 days, say officials

KABUL: Widespread flooding, landslides and lightning strikes triggered by heavy rain and storms across Afghanistan have left 77 people dead and 137 injured over the past 10 days, the country's Disaster Management Authority said Saturday.

More rain has been forecast for the coming days throughout Afghanistan, and the authority warned the public to stay away from river banks and areas prone to flooding.

So far this year, dozens of people have died due to extreme weather in Afghanistan, an impoverished country that is highly vulnerable to extreme weather events. Earlier this year, heavy snowfall and flash floods left dozens of people dead across the country. The recent toll includes 26 people killed over the past 48 hours, the disaster authority said. Overall, 793 homes have been completely destroyed and a fur-

More rain has been forecast for the coming days throughout Afghanistan, and the authority warned the public to stay away from river banks

ther 2,673 have been damaged, while floods and landslides have destroyed 337 kilometres (about 210 miles) of roads, it said.

Businesses, agricultural land, water wells and irrigation canals have also been damaged, with more than 5,800 families affected overall, the authority said. Several highways connecting the country's capital to the provinces have also been damaged by floods and landslides, forcing travellers to take long, circuitous routes to reach Kabul, Public Works

Ministry spokesman Ashraf Haqshinas said Saturday.

They include the Kabul to Jalalabad highway, which is the main route linking the capital to the Pakistani border and eastern Afghan provinces. A landslide and rockfalls, as well as flooding, shut the highway on Thursday morning, and Haqshinas said crews were working to reopen the road.

The Public Works Ministry warned travellers to be cautious when using roads in affected areas.

Flooding has also shut the Salang Pass, a high mountain pass in the Hindu Kush mountain range that connects Kabul to the country's north, including the major cities of Kunduz and Mazar-e-Sharif.

Snow and heavy rain often trigger flash floods that kill scores, or even hundreds, of people at a time in Afghanistan. In 2024, more than 300 people died in springtime flash floods. AGENCIES

Russia, Ukraine trade deadly strikes, 10 dead

KYIV: Russia and Ukraine traded deadly strikes overnight and on Saturday morning, killing 10 people and wounding several dozen more, officials on both sides said.

The attacks came as Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy travelled to Istanbul for talks with Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan. He will also meet with Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew, the spiritual leader of Eastern Orthodox Christians.

"We are working to strengthen our partnership to ensure the real protection of lives, advance stability, and guarantee security in Europe and the Middle East. Joint efforts always yield the best results," Zelenskyy said in a post on the messaging app Telegram after arriving in Istanbul. Russia fired 286 drones at Ukraine overnight, 260 of which were downed, the Ukrainian Air Force said in an online statement.

Five people — three women and two men — were killed in the city of Nikopol in the Dnipropetrovsk region, and 19

others were wounded, the head of the regional military administration Oleksandr Hanzha said. The attack damaged market stalls and a shop.

In the city of Sumy, not far from the border with Russia, a strike wounded 11 people. Residential areas were hit, and houses, cars and utility networks were damaged.

In the capital, Kyiv, a drone strike caused a fire on the first floor of a three-story office and warehouse building, Ukraine's State Emergency Service said. No casualties were reported.

In the partially occupied Donetsk region, a Russian drone strike hit a civilian car on the Kostyantynivka-Druzhkivka road on Saturday morning, killing one woman and wounding another, officials said.

Meanwhile, the Russian-installed head of the occupied Luhansk region, Leonid Pashechnik, said Ukrainian forces hit railroad infrastructure in the region and private homes, killing a family of three — a couple and their 8-year-old child. AGENCIES

Death toll from Afghan earthquake 'rises to 12'

ITTEFAQ: For several minutes after the earthquake struck, he could hear their screams. Then there was silence.

Mohibullah Niazi, a neighbour who helped in the rescue efforts, said Saturday that the eight people killed on the outskirts of Kabul after a 5.8 magnitude earthquake struck northern Afghanistan the previous night were a refugee family recently returned from neighbouring Iran.

There was only one survivor: a boy of around 3 years old, who was injured and has been hospitalised in Kabul.

Afghanistan's deputy government spokesman Hamdullah Fitrat on Saturday increased the overall death toll from the quake to 12.

Fitrat said five homes were destroyed and another 33 significantly damaged, affecting 40 families in the provinces of

Five homes were destroyed while 33 others damaged significantly

Kabul, Panjshir, Logar, Nangarhar, Laghman and Nuristan.

The Afghanistan Disaster Management Authority put the overall death toll at nine. The reason for the discrepancy was not immediately clear.

The family near Kabul was among the millions of Afghan refugees who have recently returned from Iran and Pakistan, after both countries launched crackdowns in 2023 on foreigners — particularly Afghans — living in their countries. They had arrived 15 days ago and were living in a tent on land next to Niazi's home. AGENCIES

Pakistan denies setback in US-Iran talks initiative

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Saturday rejected media reports that its initiative to facilitate talks between the US and Iran to end the ongoing conflict in West Asia had hit obstacles after the initial exchange of peace proposals.

Speculation emerged after a senior Foreign Ministry official briefed a select group of journalists on Pakistan's efforts to find a negotiated settlement of the ongoing conflict.

Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi rejected the media reports as "baseless" and a "figment of imagination."

"We have noted several reports in the media, including on social media, citing so-called official

TAKEAWAYS

» The Foreign Office spokesperson rejected the reports as 'baseless' and a 'figment of imagination'

» Pakistan took action following the onset of the war, driven in part by its obligation to defend Saudi Arabia against potential attacks from Iran

» Araghchi also dismissed media reports suggesting a stalemate in the talks

government sources regarding

the ongoing conflict in the region and Pakistan's efforts to promote peace and dialogue," he said in a statement.

Similarly, Iranian Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi dismissed Western media reports suggesting a stalemate in Pakistan-facilitated talks between Iran and the US, labelling it as "misrepresented."

"We are deeply grateful to Pakistan for its efforts and have never refused to go to Islamabad," he said in a social media post. "What we care about are the terms of a conclusive and lasting END to the illegal war that is imposed on us," Araghchi added.

Pakistan took action follow-

ing the onset of the war, driven in part by its obligation to defend Saudi Arabia against potential attacks from Iran. While Pakistan has struggled to broker a ceasefire, it has managed to distance itself from direct involvement in the conflict.

"We categorically reject these false insinuations attributed to purported official sources as baseless and a figment of imagination. Any attribution to official sources in this regard is incorrect," Andrabi said, commenting on media reports. He said that it was a matter of concern that the briefing held on Friday at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs had been "misrepresented." AGENCIES

CRACKDOWN ON DISSENTING VOICES AS WAR RAGES ON

Outspoken Iranians overseas say their loved ones 'being detained by the govt back home'

CAIRO: Iran's government is detaining family members and threatening to seize property of Iranian opposition figures in exile, some say, in the latest crackdown on dissenting voices as the war rages on.

Activists overseas play a key role in tracking the crackdown, which is complicated by the internet shutdown imposed earlier this year during massive nationwide protests against the Islamic theocracy. Watchdogs say security forces shot and killed thousands of people.

The war with the United States and Israel has intensified authorities' threats against anyone speaking to outside media or activists. Now that pressure appears to be expanding to intimidate activists in exile.

Intelligence agents in Tehran on March 15 detained the brother of Hossein Razzagh, a former political prisoner who fled last year to Europe, Razzagh said. "My own brother isn't at all political and doesn't do any kind of political activity. It's to put me under pressure," he said.



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

His brother, Ali, was taken from his home in Tehran and was able to phone his wife that night "for a few seconds" from a detention centre run by Iran's Intelligence Ministry, Razzagh said. Since then, the family and his lawyer have been unable to contact him. But the intelligence ministry told them it was reviewing his contact with his brother, Razzagh said.

Another activist who fled, Behnam Chegini, said his 20-year-old niece was detained on March 10 for a week. The niece was taken from her parents' house in the city of Arak soon after she returned from Tehran, where her university had closed because of the war.

She was later released on bail and put under a travel ban.

Chegini, who is now based in France, said the detention was at least in part "because she is my niece and they know that".

Sareh Sedighi, an activist who fled after her 2021 death sentence was overturned, said her mother was detained from her home last month in the western town of Urmia.

"The Islamic Republic took my mother away to make me be quiet," she said. Her mother suffers from health problems and requires daily insulin doses, she added.

And Mahshid Nazemi, a former political prisoner and activist

INSIGHT

» Activists overseas play a key role in tracking the crackdown

» Watchdogs say security forces shot and killed thousands of people

who now lives in France, said at least one friend was detained and questioned about contact with her.

Iran's judiciary has begun seizing the property of public figures critical of the country's rulers, under an anti-espionage law approved during last year's 12-day war with Israel that punishes media and cultural activities deemed to support Iran's enemies.

A judiciary spokesman on March 31 said on state TV that more than 200 indictments for confiscations have been or are being issued.

Borzou Arjmand, an Iranian actor living in California, found out from news reports that his assets in Iran had been confiscated. After his outspoken support for protests in 2022, Arjmand was unable to return to Iran. Since then, authorities have blocked his bank accounts.

Arjmand has expressed support on social media for Reza Pahlavi, the son of Iran's last shah who has organized an opposition movement abroad and supported US-Israeli strikes.

Pressuring exiled figures is

meant "so the Iranian people's voice doesn't reach the world", Arjmand said.

At least three other figures living outside Iran — star soccer player Sardar Azmoun, musician Mohsen Yeghaneh and university professor Ali Sharifi Zarchi — have been on lists of confiscations, according to two semiofficial news agencies in Iran. Yeghaneh and Zarchi have expressed support for anti-government protesters on social media.

Norway-based Iran Human Rights has tracked several hundred detentions since the war began on February 28, using its networks in the country and state media reports, said its director, Mahmood Amiry-Moghaddam. He said the full number is likely far higher.

Among those detained is human rights lawyer Nasrin Sotoudeh, taken by intelligence agents from her house in Tehran, said her daughter Mehravah Khandan, who lives in Amsterdam.

The 64-year-old Sotoudeh had been out on bail for health reasons following an earlier detention. AGENCIES

DC's marvelous Impact

Red-hot Rizvi, bowlers power DC to six-wicket win over MI

NEW DELHI: Impact substitute Sameer Rizvi continued his red-hot form with another fine half-century as an all-round Delhi Capitals outclassed Mumbai Indians by six wickets in their first home game of the 2026 IPL season here on Saturday.

Chasing 163, the 22-year-old Rizvi (90 off 51 balls) took apart the MI attack with a fluent knock studded with seven fours and as many sixes.

After suffering a top-order wobble for the second successive game, Delhi Capitals steadied through a 66-run stand for the third wicket between Rizvi and Pathum Nissanka, who scored 44 off 30 balls.

Rizvi then added 78 runs with David Miller (17 not out) as the hosts completed the chase with 11 balls to spare.

Initially playing second fiddle to Nissanka, Rizvi shifted gears after the Sri Lankan's dismissal, taking on the bowlers with ease.

The youngster smashed back-to-back fours followed by two towering sixes, including one over deep backward point, to plunder 20 runs off the 11th over bowled by Corbin Bosch.

He continued the assault in the next over, whipping consecutive sixes off Mayank Markande to seize complete control



Sameer Rizvi fell 10 runs short of a ton

PTI

of the chase.

He was unlucky to miss out on his debut IPL ton but received a standing ovation from the crowd when he Bosch got him out. This was

after Delhi Capitals bowlers dominated to restrict Mumbai Indians to a modest 162 for six despite stand-in skipper Suryakumar Yadav's a patient half-century.

Surya lauds Rizvi's knock

NEW DELHI: Mumbai Indians stand-in skipper Suryakumar Yadav on Saturday lauded Sameer Rizvi's brilliant batting while admitting that his team was few runs short of a par-score on a decent Kotla wicket.

"I think it was a decent wicket. We expected it to be a little on the slower side, but still from batting point of view we were a little short -- 15-20 runs, but I don't want to take any credit away from the bowlers and also their batters batted really well in the second innings," he said at the post-match presentation ceremony. Asked about Sameer Rizvi, Suryakumar said: "Absolutely, I mean at 7 for 2 someone coming in like that and batting like the way he batted, I think a lot of credit goes to him. He never let us come into the game."

AGENCIES

Suryakumar anchored the innings with a 36-ball 51, hitting three fours and two sixes, while Rohit Sharma hit 35 even as other MI batters found it difficult in the middle.

Delhi's bowlers, however, kept things tight. Skipper Axar Patel was exceptional, conceding just 22 runs in his four overs and removing the dangerous Rohit Sharma. Leg-spinner Vipraj Nigam (1/24 in 3 overs) chipped in with a wicket, while Kuldeep Yadav (0/31 in 3 overs) proved slightly expensive.

The pace trio of Mukesh Kumar (2/26), Lungi Ngidi (1/34) and T Natarajan (1/24) also played their part, sharing four wickets between them.

Mukesh struck early, removing the in-form Ryan Rickelton with a good-length delivery that was miscued to Axar at mid-off.

Two balls later, he produced a return catch to dismiss Tilak Varma for a duck, leaving Mumbai Indians two down inside the powerplay.

Rohit (35) and Suryakumar then steadied the innings with a 53-run partnership.

Rohit got going with the first six of the match, dispatching an overpitched ball from Nigam over long-on, while Suryakumar followed up with a maximum off the next delivery.

However, Delhi spinners tightened the screws after. Axar accounted for Rohit.

AGENCIES

LSG seek batting revival vs SRH

HYDERABAD: Lucknow Super Giants will need to step up their batting as they seek their first win of the season against an explosive Sunrisers Hyderabad in a tricky away IPL clash, here on Sunday. SRH head into their first home game of the season brimming with confidence after rediscovering their batting mojo, hammering 226/8 to crush Kolkata Knight Riders by 65 runs at Eden Gardens. Returning to Uppal, where conditions are expected to favour strokeplay in an afternoon game, only adds to the challenge for LSG.

AGENCIES

Deshpande leads Royals to thrilling win

AHMEDABAD: Tushar Deshpande bowled a magnificent final over by landing six consecutive deliveries on either blockhole or wide yorker length in an exhibition of high-class bowling as Rajasthan Royals edged out Gujarat Titans by six runs in an IPL humdinger here on Saturday.

This was Royals' second successive win in the tournament while the Ashish Nehra coached GT team has now lost two matches in a row. Riding on half-centuries from Dhruv Jurel (75 off 42 balls) and Yashasvi Jaiswal (55 off 36 balls), Royals scored 210 for 6 in their 20 overs.

Despite Sai Sudharsan's 73 which oozed class, GT were staring down the barrel at 161 for 7 before Kagiso Rabada (23 not out) and stand-in skipper Rashid Khan (24) took the team close to a win with 10 needed off the final over. But Deshpande had other ideas as he started the final over with a wide but then was on target with three singles and a wide fuller delivery that Rashid conceded a dot. In the end, only four runs were scored.

AGENCIES

Payal Nag stuns Sheetal, wins gold in Bangkok Para Archery; India shine

BANGKOK: Teenage quadruple amputee archer Payal Nag produced a stunning upset to defeat her world No 1 decorated teammate Sheetal Devi and clinch gold, headlining India's dominant show at the World Archery Para Series here where the country finished on top with an overwhelming seven gold.

The 18-year-old rising star won 139-136 in the compound women's final, capping a memorable campaign as India signed off with 16 medals including five silver and four bronze. This was Payal's second win over Sheetal in little over a year, having defeated her at the Para Nationals in Jaipur in January 2025. Payal, competing in only her second international event after making her debut at the Dubai 2025 Asian Youth Para Games, showed remarkable composure under pressure to get the better of her more decorated compatriot.

She began strongly with a perfect 10, taking the opening end 27-25, before Sheetal fought back to level the contest. Locked at 54-all after the



second end, Payal raised her game in the third, shooting two 9s and a 10 to move ahead 82-80, and then sealed the contest with a clinical final end that included two 10s.

A find of Sheetal's childhood coach Kuldeep Vedwan, Payal's journey has been nothing short of extraordinary.

The daughter of a migrant labourer from Odisha's Balangir district, she lost all four limbs after coming into contact with a live wire at a brick kiln in 2015. She trained alongside Sheetal at the Mata Vaishno Devi Shrine Board Sports Complex in Katra during 2023-24 before the latter shifted base to Sonapat.

AGENCIES

Gavaskar says CSK's biggest concern this IPL is bowling

CHENNAI: Former India captain Sunil Gavaskar believes five-time champions Chennai Super Kings' primary concern is their bowling, urging the side to address it to revive their campaign.

CSK have lost their first two matches of the season, including a five-wicket defeat to Punjab Kings on Friday.

"From what we've seen so far, CSK's biggest concern for the rest of the tournament will be their bowling. It means they may have to consistently score around 225-230 to give their bowlers a chance," Gavaskar said. "Most teams now have significant batting depth, like we saw with Punjab Kings where Marcus Stoinis came in at No. 7 and struck the ball cleanly with proper cricketing shots. With many sides batting deep, Chennai will need to get their bowling in order."

Young Ayush Mhatre top-scored for CSK with a 43-ball 73, guiding the team to 209 for five. "I believe Number 3 is a good position for Ayush Mhatre."

AGENCIES

Sterling Haaland

Scores hat-trick vs Liverpool to propel City to FA Cup semis



Erling Haaland celebrates after scoring a goal

AP

MANCHESTER: Erling Haaland scored a hat-trick as Manchester City crushed Liverpool 4-0 at the Etihad Stadium on Saturday to cruise into the FA Cup semi-finals.

Champions Liverpool played well in the opening half-hour with Mohamed Salah wasting an early chance, but once Haaland had scored from the spot in the 37th minute after a foul on Nico O'Reilly their resistance crumbled.

Liverpool captain Virgil van Dijk conceded the penalty with a lack challenge, and there was little the Dutch defender could do as City played scintillating attacking football for the remainder of the game.

His blond hair swinging behind him in a ponytail, Haaland netted his second two minutes into first-half stoppage time with a well-placed header

18
It was a record 18th straight home win for City in the FA Cup, dating to 2017

from an excellent Antoine Semenyo cross.

Semenyo got on the scoresheet himself five minutes after the break, latching on to a ball in behind from Rayan Cherki and chipping it beautifully past Giorgi Mamardashvili, and Haaland completed his treble with a shot off the underside of the crossbar in the 57th minute.

AGENCIES

UJVNL LIMITED
H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Letter No: 274

Tender Notice

Date: 04/04/2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil-SHP), UJVNL Ltd., Hat, Pithoragarh invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Summary of tender is given below:
Tender No - 01/EE(Civil-SHP)/Dharchula/2026-27
Name of Work: - Protection works of Approach Road near Power House at 2x2.5 MW Suringad Stage II SHP Tehsil Munyari in Distt. Pithoragarh.
Estimated cost : Rs 24,40,414/-
Date of availability of bid document on website: 06-04-2026 at 17:00 Hrs
Last date for submission of tender: 01-05-2026 up to 17:00 Hrs
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvnl.com"
Executive Engineer (Civil-SHP),
"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक का कार्यालय, राँची

सर्वसाधारण के लिए सूचना

नाम- सीमा देवी, उम्र- 30 वर्ष, उँचाई- 5 फीट, रंग-सँवला, पहनावा- किम रंग का प्रिंटेड सलवार सूट पहनी हुई है।
उपरोक्त लापता महिला सीमा देवी, उम्र-30 वर्ष, पति-संजय साहू, सा0-मंदरो, थाना-नरकोपी, जिला-राँची, जो दिनांक-21.02.2026 को घर से बगैर बताए कहीं चली जो आज तक अपने घर वापस नहीं आई है। जिसके संबंध में नरकोपी थाना सनहा संख्या-14 / 2026, दिनांक-07.03.2026 दर्ज कर इनकी खोजबीन की जा रही है। उपरोक्त सूचना को सार्वजनिक किया जाना आवश्यक है।
अतः सभी जनसाधारण से अनुरोध है कि यदि उपरोक्त लापता महिला कहीं मिलती / दिखती है तो इसके संबंध में वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक के कार्यालय में या निम्नांकित फोन नम्बर पर संपर्क कर इसकी सूचना दें।
Email ID (mc-dcb@jhpolic.gov.in)
पुलिस उपाधीक्षक, बेडो, राँची। - 9663385073
थाना प्रमारी, नरकोपी, राँची। - 9431706146
वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक, राँची
PR 376657 Police (26-27)_D

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA e - Procurement Notice
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER,
JEYPORE (R&B) CIRCLE, JEYPORE
INVITATIONS FOR BIDS (IFB)
e-mail ID- supongor_rbjyp@yahoo.com

No. 2696

Date. 30.03.2026

1. Nature of Work: Building Work

2. Total No. of Works: 01 (One) No.

3. Tender cost: Rs. 1.79 Crs.

4. Period of completion: 10 (Ten) Calendar Months.

5. Cost of Bid Document: Rs. 10,000/-

6. Bid Security (EMD): : Rs. 1.79 Lacs as per column no. 06 of IFB.

7. Class of Contractor: "B" & "A" Class as per Cl no. 05 of TCN & according to Financial Eligibility, from 12:00 hours of 09.04.2026 to 17:00 hours of 23.04.2026

8. Date & time of availability of bid Document in the portal: 17:00 hours of 23.04.2026

9. Last date /Time for receipt of bids in the Portal: 17:00 hours of 23.04.2026

10. Opening date of Bid: 11:00 hours of 24.04.2026

11. Name and address of: Chief Construction Engineer, Jeypore (R&B) Circle, Jeypore, Dt 25.01.2024 at 11:30 AM

Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>
Any addendum / corrigendum / cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website only.
Sd/-Chief Construction Engineer, Jeypore (R&B) Circle, Jeypore,

34001/34108/1/26-27/0001

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS/82 Cr.PC.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Dadan Singh S/o:** Bikhari Singh, R/o: H. No. C-324, Phase-Ist, Metro Vihar, Holambi Kalan, Delhi (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 236/2017, U/s: 33 DE Act**, registered at **P.S.: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Dadan Singh**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Dadan Singh**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Dadan Singh, FIR No.: 236/2017, U/s: 33 DE Act**, registered at **P.S.: Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.05.2026**.

By Order

Mr. Sarthak Panwar
Judicial Magistrate First Class - 05
Court No. 114, 1st Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/4232/ON/2026

(Court Matter)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER ROAD CONSTRUCTION DEPARTMENT ROAD DIVISION, KHUNTI

e-Procurement Notice

E_Tender Reference No. RCD/KHUNTI/136 Date :- 02/04/2026

1.	Name of the work	Construction of H.L. Bridge over Banai River at 8 th Km of Khunti - Torpa - Kolebira Road.
2.	Estimated Cost (Rs.)	Rs. 6,04,88,737.88 Rs. Six Crore Four Lakh Eighty Eight Thousand Seven Hundred thirty Seven and paise Eighty Eight Only.
3.	Bid Security (Rs.)	Rs. 6,05,000.00 Rs. Six Lakh Five Thousand Only.
4.	Cost of Document (Rs.)	Rs. 10,000.00 Rs. Ten Thousand Only.
5.	Time of Completion	24 Months
6.	Last date / Time for receipt of bids	04.05.2026 up to 12:00 Noon
7.	Date of Publication of Tender on website	09.04.2026 at 10:30 A.M.
8.	Name & Address of office Inviting tender	Executive Engineer, Road Construction Department, Road Division, Khunti 06528-221215
9.	Contact no. of Procurement Officer	0651-2401010
10.	Helpline number of e-Procurement Cell	0651-2401010

Note :- Estimated cost of tender can be increased or decreased
Further details can be seen on website <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in>
Executive Engineer,
R.C.D., Road Division, Khunti

PR 376677 (Road) 26-27 (D)

SEARCH OF ACCUSED/ SUSPECTED PERSONS

General public is hereby informed that few accused/ suspected persons who are depicted in this picture. **Namely:** Unknown, S/o Unknown, who are being seen in a Video Footage and complaint have registered the case against these accused/ suspected person. In this regard, a **Case FIR No. 174/2023, U/s 380/34 IPC** has been registered at **P.S. Timarpur, Delhi**. All efforts have been made to trace out the accused persons but no clue has been found till date. If anyone has any clue/ information about the accused persons then please inform to **P.S. Timarpur, Delhi** at following telephone no. **Sd/- SHO**
DP/3258/N/2026 PS: Timarpur, Delhi
(Court Notice) Phone No: 8750870130

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Azharuddin, Azharuddin Tour and Travel Pvt, R/o H.No. B-229, Gali No. 03, Mandawali Fazalpur, Sahkarpur, Delhi-110092** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CC NI Act 861/2019, U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Moti Nagar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Azharuddin** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Azharuddin** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Azharuddin** accused of **CC NI Act 861/2019, U/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Moti Nagar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.05.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Poonam Singh

Judicial Magistrate First Class (NI Act)-04
West District, Room No. 04
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/4277/WD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rahul @ Yogender Tomer, S/o Narendar Singh, R/o E-430, Gali No. 8, West Vinod Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 319/2018, U/s 457/380/411/34 IPC, P.S. Madhu Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Rahul @ Yogender Tomer** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Rahul @ Yogender Tomer** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Rahul @ Yogender Tomer** accused of **FIR No. 319/2018, U/s 457/380/411/34 IPC, P.S. Madhu Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.05.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Udhav Kumar Jain

Judicial Magistrate First Class-04
Shahdara District, Room No. 13, 2nd Floor
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/4384/ED/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.PC./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Raman, S/o:** Yogender, R/o: 329, Bhalswa Village, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 393/2017, U/s: 336/34 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Jahangir Puri, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Raman**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Raman**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Raman, FIR No.: 393/2017, U/s: 336/34 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Jahangir Puri, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.05.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-07
North District, Room No. 6, 1st Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/4312/NW/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Vijay Shankar, S/o:** Om Prakash, R/o: H.No.-135, Bakoli, P.S. Alipur, New Delhi; Also at: Mohalla Allapur, Shahabad, Hardoi, Uttar Pradesh has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 245/2024 U/s 279 IPC, P.S.: Geeta Colony, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Vijay Shankar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vijay Shankar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Vijay Shankar** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 245/2024 U/s 279 IPC, P.S.: Geeta Colony, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **07.05.2026**.

By Order

Ms. Prerna Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02 (East)
Room No. 15, Karkardooma Court, Delhi

DP/4364/SHD/2026

(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Mohseem Khan S/o Anwar Khan R/o H.No. G-98, Lal Kuan Pul Prahlapur New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 985/2015 CRC No.2266/2021 U/s 392/411/34 IPC at P.S. OIA, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrants of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mohseem Khan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mohseem Khan** have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mohseem Khan** of **FIR No. 985/2015 CRC No.2266/2021 U/s 392/411/34 IPC of P.S.: OIA, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.05.2026**.

By order

Akansa Gautam
Judicial Magistrate First Class-02
Room No.513
Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/4265/SE/2026



Narendra Modi



Donald Trump



Benjamin Netanyahu



Mojtaba Khamenei

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

As conflict engulfs the Gulf, India faces rising risks to energy security, remittance lifelines, diaspora safety and its delicate diplomatic balancing in West Asia

India's Stakes in a BURNING GULF

On February 24, the Indian Minister of Commerce and Industry, Piyush Goyal, signed a key document with Jassem Mohammad Al Budaiwi, Secretary General of the GCC. The Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) includes six member countries, namely Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Qatar, Kuwait, Oman, and Bahrain.

The next day, the Indian Prime Minister, Narendra Modi, left for a two-day (February 25–26) state visit to Israel, which was described as “extraordinarily productive”. Modi’s ill-timed Israel visit has put India firmly in the Israel-US camp, as US President Donald Trump, on Saturday (February 28, 2026), announced that his country had begun “major combat operations in Iran” after Israel launched strikes. The Indian Prime Minister’s strong support for Israel — refusal to condemn the Israel-US strikes on Iran and delay in condoling the assassination of Iran’s Supreme Leader, a long-time friend of India — has diminished India’s stature in the eyes of the world.”

Over 50 per cent of the GCC’s population comprises expatriates, with Indians leading at 9.5 million and Bangladeshis at 5 million. India has individual pacts with key GCC members like the UAE and Oman to strengthen economic ties. India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) was signed in 2022, and India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) was concluded in 2025. Prolonged war in the Middle East has put millions of the Indian diaspora in a severe crisis.

As per January 2025 data revealed in Parliament, out of the total 17.2 million Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), as many as 9.6 million, representing 55.76 per cent of global NRIs, reside in the Middle East. The size of the Indian community in GCC countries stands at 9.54 million. Out of this, the UAE hosts more than 30 lakh Indians, Saudi Arabia over 30 lakh, and Kuwait

over 1 lakh. Qatar and Oman host over 5 lakh each, while Bahrain has the smallest number in the GCC.

In that regard, despite the prolonged conflict — which has intensified since October 7, 2022 — Israel hosts 1,23,000 Indians. Before the 12-day Israel-Iran conflict in June, Iran had over ten thousand Indians, most of them being religious pilgrims and students. Iraq, which is slowly limping towards normalcy after decades of internal turmoil, has over 17,000 Indians, while resource-scarce Jordan is home to over 16,000 Indians.

India is the world’s largest recipient of remittances, with record-high inflows amounting to USD 135 billion (EUR 117 billion) in 2025. India took in nearly USD 40 billion in remittances from GCC countries alone, accounting for about 38 per cent of its total inflows. The UAE accounted for around 20 per cent of total Indian remittance inflow.

GULF COUNTRIES IN CRISIS

After four weeks of the US-Israel joint invasion of the Islamic Republic of Iran, the war situation has turned complicated. In a strategic move, Iran has targeted Gulf countries, which act as vassal states of the USA and allow US military bases for the protection of their oil infrastructure and the ruling Arab monarchs of Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, and Oman.

In retaliation, Iranian forces have launched attacks in the Middle East where US troops are deployed, as well as Israeli military facilities in Tel Aviv and

other parts of Israel. So far, Iran has launched strikes across nine countries in the region: Bahrain, Iraq, Jordan, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE. An Iranian drone also struck a runway at a United Kingdom military base in Cyprus.

Tehran sees several GCC monarchies not as neutral neighbours but as part of a wider US-led security architecture in the region. That perception is influenced by the long presence of Western military bases and by the political afterlife of the Abraham Accords, which began formal normalisation between Israel and the UAE and Bahrain in 2020. In Iran’s view, the Gulf cannot claim neutrality while remaining tied to American security power and, in some cases, to new arrangements with Israel, observes The Hindu.

Iranian missile strikes sparked fires near luxury hotels and data centres in Dubai, caused panic at Kuwait’s international airport, and put Saudi Arabia’s largest oil refinery out of commission. Qatar has shut down its liquefied natural gas (LNG) exports. Oman suffered successive Iranian drone attacks targeting its Duqm port complex. Bahrain’s oil installations have also been attacked.

Desalination plants in the GCC countries are most vulnerable at this stage, as all six Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) nations critically rely on desalination plants for their water supply. Desalination fulfils 77.3 per cent of total water demand in Qatar, 67.5 per cent in Bahrain, 52.1 per cent in the UAE, 42.2 per cent in Kuwait, 31 per cent in Oman, and 18.1 per cent in Saudi Arabia. Desalination facilities

in Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) suffered indirect damage from missile and drone strikes early in the conflict.

For these oil-exporting GCC countries, there is an immediate concern that the Houthis in Yemen, either for their own interests or at Iran’s behest, might enter the conflict. If the group does get involved, it would likely do so by restarting attacks on ships transiting the Red Sea and the Bab al-Mandeb Strait — threatening the flow of an additional 12 per cent of international seaborne oil transits and 8 per cent of global liquefied natural gas trade. For shipping companies, these attacks would add to the already rising costs from the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, through which 20 per cent of global oil and gas tankers pass.

CONTRADICTIONS WITHIN GCC: UAE — A ‘ZIONIST TROJAN HORSE’

In a scathing article published a few weeks before the war by Saudi academic and former Shura Council member Dr Ahmed bin Othman Al-Tuwaijri, the Emirates is described as exploiting its alliances with Zionist Israel to challenge Saudi Arabia and other major Arab powers. Al-Tuwaijri argues that the UAE’s strategic alliance with Israel is motivated by long-standing animosity towards Saudi Arabia, jealousy over its religious, geopolitical, and economic stature, and a misguided attempt by Abu Dhabi to assert regional dominance. He characterises the Emirati-Israeli partnership as a calculated betrayal of Arab and Islamic unity, stating that Abu

“WHAT HAPPENS IN THE MIDDLE EAST IS NOT GOING TO STAY THERE”

Dhabi has “thrown itself into the arms of Zionism,” serving as a “Zionist Trojan horse” within the Arab world, enabling Israeli influence and destabilising the region to serve Tel Aviv’s ambitions.

A week before the invasion of Iran, Mike Huckabee, the United States Ambassador to Israel — an avowed Christian Zionist and staunch defender of Israel — suggested that he would not object if Israel were to take most of the Middle East, stressing what he described as the Jewish people’s right to the land. Such a swath would encompass modern-day Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, and parts of Saudi Arabia.

It is alleged that Benjamin Netanyahu’s recognition of “Somaliland” in December 2025 — a breakaway part of Somalia — represents the culmination of a long and complex trajectory of clandestine relations, and comes as part of a broader regional project to redraw maps of influence in the Horn of Africa and the Red Sea in ways that

serve the interests of Tel Aviv and its trusted allies, foremost among them Abu Dhabi. Notably, the UAE had previously sought to secure international recognition for Somaliland through the United Nations, though these efforts failed. These initiatives formed part of a wider Emirati strategy to construct an empire of influence centred on control over ports, strategic waterways — including the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden — military bases, and key trade and energy routes, in coordination with the United States and Israel.

This explains why no country, other than Israel, has been hit harder by Iran than the United Arab Emirates. It appears Iran is looking to inflict maximum regional and global pain, testing a state that has positioned itself as an ally of Israel and the USA, the Gulf’s safest bridge between East and West, and the future of the region.

OBSERVATIONS

The future of millions of Indian and other South Asian citizens earning their livelihood in the Middle East region, especially in the Gulf countries, is uncertain at this stage, as millions of South Asian workers in the Middle East provide a vital economic boost by sending money home. Economists warn these flows would be at risk if a protracted conflict dents the Gulf region’s economies. Most people killed in Iran’s Gulf attacks have been from South Asia, and entire economies back home are on edge, reports Al Jazeera.

The present crisis will accelerate the shift of global energy demand from fossil to

non-fossil fuels, reducing the economic importance of oil- and gas-rich Gulf countries. China’s State Grid will spend 4 trillion yuan (USD 574 billion) to upgrade the country’s power grid between 2026 and 2030, a 40 per cent increase in spending, state-run Xinhua news agency said. This massive project aims to boost west-to-east power transmission, integrating renewable energy with 15 new Ultra-High Voltage (UHV) lines to meet carbon reduction goals. With the drop in demand for petroleum, the hegemony of the petrodollar is bound to decline.

Global capital is likely to migrate to safer havens. Colombo Port City in Sri Lanka may emerge as an alternative to Dubai, Abu Dhabi, and Muscat. Colombo Port City, developed by China Harbour Engineering Company (CHEC) as a flagship Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) project, aims to facilitate connections to the South Asian market through investment opportunities, international business environments, world-class infrastructure, and high-quality sustainable living. Sri Lanka is already offering tax holidays of up to 15 years and positioning Colombo Port City as a new financial and trade hub as it seeks to attract UAE investors.

In an emerging new world order, the Zionist dream of ‘Greater Israel’ in the Arabian region of the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) does not look feasible in the near future. The dream map of the “Proposed Boundary of ‘Greater Israel’” marks an area including all of Jordan, Lebanon, Syria, and the Sinai Peninsula; the Nile delta region of Egypt along the Suez Canal and northwest of Cairo; and virtually all of Iraq, including access to the Persian Gulf. It also includes a large portion of north-western Saudi Arabia, a corridor well over 100 miles wide along the Red Sea, stretching south more than 450 miles from the Gulf of Aqaba to the Holy City of Medina. Nonetheless, the existing Zionist state of Israel is becoming increasingly isolated across the world, including in the USA.

Although Iran, a member of the BRICS+ bloc, has asked India, which holds the rotating chairmanship of BRICS this year, to support its bid to condemn the joint US and Israeli military campaign against it, New Delhi has so far resisted calls to intervene. India’s alignment with Israel and the USA during this Iran crisis has raised questions about its ethical voice on the principles of sovereignty, anti-colonialism, and global justice.



40 LAKH
DREAMS

6
MARKET KINGS

14
DISTANT LOSERS



Indian Auto's Big Six

India's booming car market looks fiercely competitive. Yet, behind the glittering showrooms, only half-a-dozen auto firms control the gears and steering column

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

Viewed from a distance, India's auto market looks like a crowded bazaar. Dozens of brands jostle for attention, showrooms gleam across cities and glossy billboards and advertisements promise ever more features, safety and sophistication. But move closer, scratch the surface and a different reality emerges. India's car market is not a bustling democracy, but an oligarchy – a battlefield where a handful of generals effectively spit out the bullets, woo the rank and file, and pulverize the enemy.

The numbers tell the story. In 2025, India sold more than 44 lakh passenger vehicles, making it one of the world's largest and fastest-growing automobile markets globally. Yet, the lion's share of those cars came from just six companies – Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Motors, Hyundai Motor India, Toyota Kirloskar Motor and Kia India. Together, these Big Six account for over 90 per cent of the passenger vehicle market. Maruti Suzuki alone commands close to 40 per cent of sales, more than many other competitors combined.

Below this dominant tier lies a long list of brands fighting for crumbs – the Indian arms of Honda Cars, MG Motor, Renault, Nissan Motor, Citroën and Jeep. Some of these are global giants with illustrious histories. But in India, they struggle to break even 2-per cent marketshare. The contrast could not be sharper – six kings sprint on the highway, while a dozen hopefuls are stuck in toll-booth traffic.

THE NETWORK GAME

The overbearing reason for this imbalance is far less glamorous than horsepower: it is distribution power. After all, India is not a single automobile market, but a mosaic of hundreds of micro-markets – from bustling metros and still-prosperous Tier-2 towns to dusty rural districts where roads are still seen only in dreams. Winning on rutty, fissured terrain demands not merely a good car; it also needs an army of dealerships, service centres and spare-parts depots.

This is where the incumbents have built their fortresses. Maruti Suzuki began knitting together its dealer and service network decades ago, long

THE WHEELSPIN

MANUFACTURER	FEB-26	FEB-25	% GROWTH
	1,53,820	1,17,704	30.7%
	56,204	38,247	47.0%
	52,800	39,396	34.0%
	45,516	37,970	19.9%
	26,095	21,067	23.9%
	24,983	18,684	33.7%
	4,759	5,131	-7.3%
	4,536	4,504	0.7%
	7,578	6,405	18.3%
	3,240	2,515	28.8%
	1,616	1,685	-4.1%
Others	1,007	707	42.4%



INDIAN FIRMS ZOOM AHEAD
Tata Motors and M&M Auto push Hyundai back. Maruti Suzuki is miles ahead



before most foreign automakers looked seriously at India. Today, its reach stretches across thousands of touchpoints, making it possible to buy or repair a car even in remote towns. That network translates directly into trust. Trust leads to sales. The same logic applies to rivals. Hyundai Motor India invested aggressively in nationwide distribution in the early 2000s. More recently, domestic champions such as Tata Motors and Mahindra & Mahindra have expanded deep into semi-urban India.

For smaller players, the gap is daunting. A limited dealership footprint means potential buyers worry about servicing, spare parts and resale value. In a price-sensitive country where the car is often the second-largest household purchase after a home, such anxieties can kill a sale before it begins.

THE SUV JUGGERNAUT

If networks built the foundations of dominance, changing consumer taste has

widened the moat. India has witnessed an SUV revolution, with buyers moving away from traditional hatchbacks and sedans toward compact and mid-size SUVs. Automakers that predicted this shift are now reaping the rewards.

Mahindra & Mahindra rode the trend with models such as the Scorpio, Thar and the XUV series. Tata Motors struck gold with the Nexon and Punch. Hyundai Motor India and Kia India flooded the market with smaller but stylish SUVs like the Creta, Venue, Seltos and Sonet. Toyota Kirloskar Motor, in turn, leveraged its formidable reputation in premium SUVs with models like the Fortuner.

Lagging brands simply missed the timing. Honda Cars India remained heavily reliant on sedans such as the City for years, even as consumer tastes shifted decisively toward SUVs. Others launched promising models, but failed to update them quickly enough. Their trot just couldn't match the gallop of the Big Six. In a

hyper-competitive market, missing a trend didn't just hurt; it erased relevance itself.

TRUST AND VALUE

Brand psychology has been another decisive factor. Indian buyers care deeply about reliability, resale value and cost of ownership. A vehicle is not merely transportation; it is a financial asset expected to hold value over time. That explains why models from Maruti Suzuki dominate the used-car market and retain exceptional resale value. Its WagonR and Swift line-up regularly top resale rankings, similar to Toyota's Innova and Mahindra's Scorpio.

Such perception creates a powerful feedback loop. Strong resale value attracts buyers. More buyers increase marketshare. High volumes improve the availability of

service and spare parts, building even more trust. Breaking into this cycle is extraordinarily difficult. Brands that lack scale or reputation find themselves trapped outside the golden circle, no matter how good their cars may be.

Regulation and localisation have reshaped the battlefield too. In the last decade, India has introduced sweeping changes; from BS-VI emission norms and stricter safety regulations to growing expectations around electrification. Compliance demands investment in R&D, manufacturing and supply chains. Large players have the resources to absorb these costs. Tata Motors, for one, has invested aggressively in electric vehicles, emerging as the leader in India's EV passenger segment. Domestic manufacturers such as Mahindra & Mahindra are now building entirely new electric platforms.

Heavy localisation also helps. Companies that manufacture extensively within India can price vehicles aggressively while protecting margins. Those reliant on imports or low localisation struggle to match prices in a market where even a Rs 20,000 difference can sway buyers.

THE SILVER LINING

For the laggards, the challenge is stark, but not impossible. India's auto market is expanding, driven by rising incomes, urbanisation and better road infrastructure. Yet, the era of tentative commitment is over.

To survive, and perhaps someday challenge the incumbents, global automakers must adopt a far deeper India strategy. That would entail building larger dealer networks,

localising production extensively and launching products tailored specifically to Indian tastes, not repurposing international models. It also means recognising the cultural and emotional dimensions of the Indian car buyer. For most Indians, trust, practicality and value often outweigh sheer brand prestige.

For now, India's auto sector resembles a highway where only a few truly control the wheel. But history shows us that any industry built on dominance can be turned on its head by technological upheaval. EVs, software-defined cars and new platforms could redraw the competitive map faster than anyone expects. The giants may rule today, but even kings need to keep an eye on the rear-view mirror.

WELLNESS

INSIDE THE MIDLIFE CRUNCH



As responsibilities converge in midlife, many individuals find themselves balancing caregiving, careers and identity, navigating a quiet crisis that often goes unspoken

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

“I’m in my early forties. My parents are ageing and need help. My children still depend on me. Work is demanding. Financial responsibilities keep growing. Everyone seems to need something from me. I feel constantly stretched and exhausted. Sometimes, I even wonder if I’m failing at everything. Is something wrong with me?”

The short answer is no. Nothing is wrong with you. What you are experiencing is increasingly described as the “midlife squeeze.”

What is the midlife squeeze?

This phase typically occurs between the late thirties and early fifties. It is the period when multiple life responsibilities converge simultaneously. Individuals may find themselves supporting ageing parents, raising children, managing demanding careers, maintaining relationships, and navigating financial pressures all at the same time. It can feel like being pulled in multiple directions, with very little space left for oneself.

Psychologically, this period is not just about logistics and responsibilities. It is also about identity, purpose, and meaning.

Why does it occur?

Developmental psychologist Erik Erikson described this stage of life as “Generativity vs. Stagnation,” which typically occurs during middle adulthood. According to Erikson, individuals in this stage are driven by a deep need to contribute to others and to the next generation. This may involve parenting, mentoring, caregiving, building institutions, or creating something meaningful that outlasts oneself.

When this drive for generativity is fulfilled, people often experience a sense of purpose, productivity, and psychological richness. However, when responsibilities feel overwhelming or when individuals feel unappreciated or unsupported, the experience can shift toward stagnation. People may feel emotionally drained, resentful, invisible, or stuck in routines that leave little room for personal growth. This tension between contribution and exhaustion is the crux of the midlife squeeze.

Another factor contributing to this experience is being part of the “sandwich generation.” Many adults in midlife simultaneously support both children and ageing parents. Unlike earlier generations, people today often have children later in life, while parents live longer. The result is a prolonged period in which caregiving responsibilities overlap across generations.

The emotional load can be heavy. Many individuals describe persistent guilt: guilt for not spending enough time with children, guilt for not being available enough for ageing parents, guilt for focusing on work, and sometimes guilt for simply wanting personal space.

In addition, midlife is often the stage when people start questioning earlier life choices. Career paths, relationships, ambitions, and dreams are reassessed. Some individuals realise they have spent years prioritising stability over passion. Others feel trapped by commitments that once felt meaningful. All of this can create a sense of psychological compression.

How to navigate through this phase?

The first step is recognition. Many people assume they are alone in feeling this way, when in reality, it is an extremely common developmental experience.

It is important to redefine success during this phase of life. Individuals benefit from shifting toward flexible priorities and accepting that some areas of life will require more attention at different times.

THE MIDLIFE years, once seen as stable, now bring intense pressure as individuals juggle multiple demanding roles simultaneously

Boundaries become essential. People in midlife often operate in chronic “giver mode.” Learning to protect time for personal rest, hobbies, and relationships is not selfish. It is psychologically protective. Even small rituals, such as daily walks, exercise, reading, or social connections, can create emotional breathing space.

Another important step is reconnecting with personal meaning. Generativity does not only mean fulfilling duties. It also means creating something that feels purposeful. This could involve mentoring younger colleagues, contributing to community projects, revisiting creative passions, or pursuing new learning opportunities.

How can therapy help?

This is where therapy can play a powerful role. Therapy during midlife is often less about crisis and more about clarity. A skilled therapist helps individuals examine their roles, expectations, and emotional burdens. Many clients discover that they have internalised unrealistic standards of responsibility. Therapy creates space to re-evaluate these expectations and to develop healthier boundaries.

Midlife is the moment when people have enough experience to understand themselves deeply and enough time ahead to shape the life they want. The goal is not to escape responsibility. The goal is to carry it in a way that leaves room for meaning, connection, and psychological well-being.

One World, Many Words

In lieu of the weekly book review, I am sharing with my readers the key points of my keynote address at the Max City VoW Litfest at the National Gallery of Modern Art, Mumbai, on March 29

AUTHOR



SANJEEV CHOPRA

At this Max City-VoW Litfest, let me dwell on the theme 'One World, Many Words', as well as on Max City and VoW! The keyword, of course, is the 'word'—for nothing can exist without it. And then we shall try to understand its relation to the world, the host city, and VoW—the organisation that has extended its curatorial support to this festival. So from the Valley of Words, it is now Words on Waves, for the Maritime History Society of India is a partner in this endeavour.

As this is the Easter Week, let me take a moment to recall the Gospel (King James Version): *In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.* Thus, it was the word which created the world. In the Vedantic tradition, the relationship between the word and the world is more nuanced. The eighth chapter of the *Bhagavad Gita* is the Akshar Brahma Yoga. The 'word' is called Akshar—the imperishable and the eternal—as against 'Kshar'—the temporal which constitutes the world. The Lord Almighty identifies himself with Akshar. In the Sikh scriptural tradition, the word of the Guru (Gurbani) has been elevated to divine status—the living Guru. The Muslims believe the Holy Quran to be the literal, uncreated word of God (Allah), revealed in Arabic to the Prophet Muhammad. For the Jews, the Torah is the word of God.

Thus, in both Judaic and Brahmanical traditions, the word is supreme. For it is this word which helps us define our world. As civilisations evolve, we need more words in the lexicon to explain the many different nuances. For that matter, the foundational architecture of all AI—Grok, ChatGPT, Gemini, and DeepSeek—is the large language model, based on the algorithm of the most probable sequence of words.

THE WORLD WE INHABIT

What is the nature of the world we inhabit? Well, at one



FROM SACRED TEXTS TO MODERN ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE, FROM MIGRATION TO METROPOLIS, WORDS EMERGE AS THE *enduring thread* THAT BINDS CIVILISATIONS, IDENTITIES AND HISTORIES INTO A SHARED, EVOLVING NARRATIVE

level, it is just one world—even though every single individual would have their own way of describing it. But we have to remember that even though there is one world, there are an infinite number of worldviews—and infinite ways to describe them. Words are evolving all the time to get to the most proximate understanding of the world. However, even when the world has transitioned from that particular reality, the words used to describe an extant circumstance continue to live long thereafter. It is true that words can change their meaning over time, but the frequency of their use may come down—but the word can never really become a vestigial organ. It is through words that memory is preserved, and memory is the

seed from which great literature is created. Not every seed germinates, but even those that do not become part of the value chain find a manifestation. Nothing is ever lost!

As this Litfest is being held in the Maximum City, let me also talk about Suketu Mehta, the author of the eponymous book on this metropolis, for it also lends its name to the festival. This descriptor has stuck to the city not because it was notified in the *sarkari* gazette, or the manifesto of a political party, or a resolution of the Legislative Assembly. It is Max City Litfest, for this resonates well with the city: its joys, its frustrations, its ambitions, its glamour as well as its grime. It encapsulates

the agony and the ecstasy of its teeming millions, as well as the elite layers, because everything this city does is 'maximum', which Gen Z now calls Max!

This is the year when the Census of India is being held after a hiatus of fifteen years, as against the normal frequency of ten. This will bring, in its wake, an empirical verification of two

interlinked anecdotal truths: that India is urbanising, and India is now home to large swathes of interstate migration—thereby bringing some dissonance between the state and society. This is so aptly captured in Mehta's recent book *This Land Is Our Land: An Immigrant's Manifesto*, in which he shows how metros and cultural spaces are created by the intermingling of peoples who speak multiple tongues, wear multiple identities on their sleeve, bring different skill sets to the table, and create a new world—which then looks for words to describe it—thereby creating a virtuous cycle of words and the world!

Let me also share my favourite example about the evolution of words in the English language, and how it has come to dominate the world of governance, banking, commerce, culture, science, technology, peace, and war. When Shakespeare wrote his *Macbeth* and *The Tempest*, his *Hamlet* and *The Merchant of Venice* (illustrative examples), in the sixteenth century, he used over 30,000 words to describe the entire range of human emotion. When Samuel Johnson published his *Dictionary of the English Language* in 1775, he listed more than 40,000 words. But hold on—the Oxford English Dictionary of 2026 has over 5,20,000 entries, with 880,000 meanings, and the usage examples run into millions.

Let me end by quoting my favourite lines from an exiled poet of this city, Salman Rushdie. The closing lines of his *Victory City* read as follows: *I have lived to see an empire rise and fall*

*How are they remembered now
These kings... those queens
They exist now only in words
While they lived, they were victors
or vanquished, or both
Now they are neither*

*Words are the only victors
What they did or thought or felt
No longer exists
All that remains is the city of words*

Part I

Boundaries of Climate Models



Climate models underpin global policy decisions, yet their limitations, uncertainties and computational trade-offs reveal the complexity of predicting a system as vast as Earth

AUTHOR



KRISHNA GUPTA

In the last two articles, we discussed the hierarchy of various climate models, starting from simple zero-dimensional Energy Balance Models to the complex General Circulation Models (GCMs) and Earth System Models (ESMs). However, constructing models, running simulations, and then interpreting the results is far from simple. Further, each model and its simulations lead to different pathways. In climate models, one is dealing with many probability distributions, and climate change is a change in these distributions. Finally, the global climate model is just that: a simplified representation of the real world in the form of thousands of equations and millions of variables. The reality may be quite different. Let us discuss these issues in more detail here.

THE BASICS OF CLIMATE MODEL BUILDING

Most climate models are based on the fundamental laws of physics and chemistry and simulate the process of transfer of energy, gases, and matter through various parts of the climate system. These fundamental laws include the laws of conservation of energy and conservation of mass, Newton's second law of motion, and the ideal gas law (which defines the relationship between pressure, volume, and temperature of a gas). These models divide the Earth into 3D grids, with each grid having specified variables such as temperature, pressure, density, wind speed, etc. Based on the fundamental laws of physics, each grid is characterised by a set of equations, which tell us how the variables change over a period of time. This period of time is called a 'time step' and can vary from a few seconds to hundreds of years, but is typically 10 minutes, which means that the model produces calculations for each grid every 10 minutes. Inter-grid exchange of matter and energy takes place in the model to approximate real-world processes. Each grid is typically 100 km by 100 km, though smaller grids are being built with a rise in computational power.

The climate model solves the equations for each grid based on today's values. This is repeated for the next time period, and these iterations continue

until you reach a point in the future that you want to analyse and predict. GCMs and ESMs solve millions of such equations to predict the climate over large periods (100 years or up to the year 2100). A climate model is run and tested through a process called 'hindcasting'. This requires the specification of initial conditions (for example, many models specify the pre-industrial conditions of 1850 as a starting point to measure the effects of greenhouse gases on the rise in temperature over the past centuries). The model run gives us outputs of various important variables, such as changes in temperature or sea levels, etc. Various simulations can also be run with the model to help guide decision-makers in policy-making.

It is important to note here that the time step is an important constraint while running models. Many GCMs use a 10-minute time step to enable them to deal with high-resolution detail such as local weather (e.g., hurricanes). What is gained in high-resolution detail is lost in predictions that are not very long into the future. Ultimately, a balance has to be struck between geographical resolution, timeframe, and computing resources.

CLIMATE MODELS power global climate policy—but they are not crystal balls

Climate models are, of course, tools in a climate scientist's armoury and are used to study the climate system and climate change. They are, however, only the first step. There are still many issues that need to be resolved, such as greenhouse gases, clouds, rainfall, and thunderstorms, which are not captured by the equations in each grid box. The way to get around these is through 'parameterisation', which we will discuss below. There is also the issue of modelling the oceans, their surface temperature, salinity, and ocean currents.

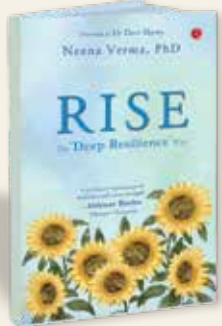
It may be noted that the climate system and climate change are very different: the climate system is the climate of all the interconnected parts, such as the Earth, atmosphere, land, oceans, and ice sheets, as it exists. As David Stainforth has suggested in his book *Predicting Our Climate Future*, climate change has many aspects, ranging from climate prediction to extrapolation, probabilities of outcomes (as he says: "Climate change is a one-shot bet"), and non-linearity (similar to sensitivity to initial conditions, or the butterfly effect). Let us discuss these issues in more detail in Part II.

Books

Strength Beyond Survival

Neena Verma's latest book moves beyond conventional ideas of resilience, offering a layered, experiential framework rooted in adversity, reflection and personal transformation

ANINDITA ACHARYA



Life is a labyrinth of misery. It brings us rainbows and rainstorms alike. But author Neena Verma, a scholarly practitioner and educator and an ICF-credentialed PCC-level coach, helps readers recognise, kindle, cultivate, embody and nourish a resilience mindset and deep resilience through her latest book, *Rise: The 'Deep Resilience' Way*, published by Rupa Publications.

Through her extensive applied research, professional practice and lived wisdom, she brings relatable models to readers. In *Rise: The 'Deep Resilience' Way*, Verma has divided the book into three parts, starting with *Strength in Storm*, which comprises sub-chapters like *When Thunder Strikes*, *Own Weather* and *Navigate the Storm*, and *Invoke Resilience Mindset*. The second part, titled *A Call to Rise: The Deep Resilience Way*, has sub-chapters on resilience, restorative adaptation,



RISE IS A TRANSFORMATIVE APPROACH TO RESILIENCE. IT MOVES BEYOND THE LIMITED IDEA OF 'bouncing back'. IT EXPLORES RESILIENCE AS A DEEP, RESTORATIVE AND GENERATIVE LIFE FORCE

imaginal growth, supple strength, and expansive emergence. In the last part of the book, titled *Nourish the Wellspring: Every Day... Every Way*, the author takes readers on a deep resilience journey in life every day and in every way.

Dr Devi Shetty, who wrote the foreword, said Verma offers a fresh perspective on resilience that goes beyond its common meaning of bouncing back. Dr Shetty praises her PRISM framework and her concept of deep resilience.

Throughout the book, the author presents various incidents from her life, such as the one in 1982 in Delhi when she was hospitalised with dengue or how she went to an exam centre with a blood-soaked, bandaged hand. Having weathered many life storms, she says that owning and honouring vulnerability is the way forward.

One of her interesting sub-chapters is *Mindset Matters*, where Verma mentions how our response to and coping with various challenges are determined by our

mindset. The PRISM framework of resilience mindset is sure to engage readers.

Another moving sub-chapter describes how Verma, a prize-winning alumna of the University of Delhi, learnt a new perspective on resilience from her elder son, Utkarsh, in 2004. She called him her "Little Shakespeare," and the boy weathered multiple adversities and trauma but emerged stronger and kinder each time. In fact, Verma recalls how he wrote an essay on resilience at the age of just 12. But destiny had other plans, and Utkarsh passed away in 2014. To Verma, he was an inspiring teacher of resilience who gave her purpose. Her younger son, Pratyush, gave her strength during the writing of the book.

Dr Verma is a lifelong seeker, practitioner, and facilitator of deep resilience. She also runs an independent library endeavour in the service of children from underserved backgrounds. Her last book was 'Grief... Growth... Grace: A Sacred Pilgrimage'.



From April 2026, the EU's Entry/Exit System has replaced passport stamps with biometric checks, digitally recording the entry and exit of non-EU travellers

AUTHOR



VINOD KUMAR

For years, a small but satisfying ritual awaited travellers landing in Europe: the immigration officer flipping open the passport, pressing down a stamp, and marking the beginning of a journey. That familiar thud of ink on paper—sometimes hurried, sometimes ceremonial—has been a quiet part of travel lore. From April 2026, however, that moment will largely disappear across the Schengen Area. Europe is moving decisively into a new era of digital borders.

The European Union's Entry/Exit System (EES) will replace manual passport stamping with a biometric registration process that digitally records the arrival and departure of visitors from outside the EU. The system will apply to travellers entering the Schengen Area for short stays—generally up to 90 days within a 180-day period. Instead of a stamp, the border checkpoint will capture a traveller's facial photograph and fingerprints, linking them to passport details stored in a secure central database.

For Indian travellers—among the fastest-growing groups visiting Europe—the change may initially feel unfamiliar. But it also reflects a broader transformation underway in global travel, where digital verification and



biometric identification are becoming the new norm.

A DIFFERENT FIRST IMPRESSION OF EUROPE

Imagine landing in Paris, Rome or Amsterdam a few years from now. The immigration hall may look slightly different. Alongside the familiar counters, travellers could encounter automated kiosks or biometric scanners. On the first visit after the system becomes operational, border authorities will collect a facial image and fingerprints before allowing entry. The process may take a little longer than the traditional passport stamp, especially as travellers and officials

adapt to the system.

But the experience is designed to improve with time. Once a traveller's biometric information has been registered, future entries into the Schengen Area are expected to be faster. Instead of repeating the full process, border officials can verify the stored biometric profile, allowing identity checks to be completed more quickly.

In effect, the first trip becomes a kind of digital enrolment. After that, the system recognises you.

WHY EUROPE IS CHANGING THE RULES

The Entry/Exit System is part of a broader European effort to modernise border management. The traditional passport-stamp system, which has existed for decades, is surprisingly limited in the digital age. Stamps can be unclear or misplaced, making it difficult for authorities to track exactly when someone entered or left the region.

The EES changes that. Every crossing of the Schengen border will generate a digital record that includes the time and place of entry or exit, along with biometric identifiers. Authorities will automatically calculate how long a traveller has remained in the region.

For European governments, this serves multiple purposes. It helps detect overstays, strengthens the fight against identity fraud, and improves overall border security.

For travellers, the system could eventually reduce the confusion that sometimes surrounds the Schengen 90-day rule. Anyone who has tried to count their remaining days after multiple trips to Europe will appreciate the clarity of an automated calculation.

A ROLLOUT YEARS IN THE MAKING

Although travellers will notice the system from April 2026, its story

THE FIRST MONTHS MAY BE BUMPY

Like any large technological shift, the transition may not be perfectly smooth. Airports and airlines have already warned that queues could initially grow longer as biometric registration is introduced and passengers learn the new procedures. In peak travel periods, some industry groups fear waits could stretch significantly if infrastructure or staffing falls short.

For travellers, the advice is simple: allow extra time at immigration, especially during the first year of the rollout.

Frequent travellers may also notice subtle changes in how border checks work. Some airports are expected to install self-service kiosks, allowing travellers to scan their passports and register biometrics before approaching a border officer. Others may rely on dedicated biometric counters.

The experience will vary from country to country at first, but the goal is a more consistent system across Europe's external borders.

NOT A VISA—AND NOT THE LAST CHANGE

One important detail travellers should remember is that the Entry/Exit System does not replace visas. Visa rules remain unchanged. If a traveller requires a Schengen visa, the application process remains the same.

However, the EES is only one piece of Europe's evolving border framework. Another system—the European Travel Information and Authorisation System (ETIAS)—is expected to follow later. ETIAS will require visa-free travellers to apply online for pre-travel authorisation before entering the Schengen Area.

In other words, Europe is gradually building a layered digital border: biometric identity verification through EES and pre-travel screening through ETIAS.

TRAVEL IN THE AGE OF BIOMETRIC BORDERS

In some ways, the Entry/Exit System reflects a deeper shift in how countries manage movement across borders. Passports remain essential, but the future of travel increasingly relies on digital identity—data that can be verified instantly across networks.

Airports are experimenting with biometric boarding gates. Some immigration systems already use facial recognition for automated entry. Even hotel check-ins and airline security procedures are moving toward contactless identification.

Europe's new system fits squarely into that global trend.

For travellers, the experience may feel different at first: fewer stamps, more scanners. But the essence of travel—arriving somewhere new, stepping into unfamiliar streets, discovering another culture—remains unchanged.

Only the border itself is evolving. And the next time you land in Europe, the immigration officer may not reach for a stamp. Instead, a quiet flash from a camera and a fingerprint scan will record your arrival—digitally marking the beginning of another journey.



GASTRONOMY

KUNAFACHOCOLATE DELIGHT



INGREDIENTS

- » Kunafa pastry (shredded) — 200 g
- » Milk chocolate (chopped) — 200 g
- » Unsalted butter (melted) — 80 g
- » Pistachio paste — 3 tbsp
- » Fresh cream — 100 ml
- » Powdered sugar — 1 tbsp
- » Pistachios (finely chopped) — 2 tbsp
- » Vanilla essence — ½ tsp
- » White chocolate (optional, melted) — 50 g
- » Edible rose petals (optional) — for garnish

DIRECTIONS

Begin by preparing the kunafa layer. Loosen the shredded kunafa pastry with your hands so the strands separate easily. In a wide pan, melt the butter over medium heat and add the kunafa strands. Toast them slowly, stirring frequently, until they turn golden and crisp. This step is important because the crunchy texture gives the dessert its signature contrast. Once evenly toasted, remove the kunafa from the heat and allow it to cool slightly. In another saucepan, warm the fresh cream gently without bringing it to a boil. Add the chopped milk chocolate and stir continuously until it melts into a smooth, glossy mixture. Stir in the vanilla essence and powdered sugar. The result should be a rich chocolate ganache that will form the creamy centre of the dessert. Take a serving dish or small dessert cups and begin layering. Spread a portion of the toasted kunafa at the bottom, pressing it lightly to form a base. Spoon a layer of warm chocolate ganache over the crispy pastry and swirl in a little pistachio paste for a nutty flavour. Add another thin layer of kunafa on top to create a crunchy finish. For garnish, sprinkle chopped pistachios over the surface and drizzle a little melted white chocolate if desired. The dessert can be served slightly warm so the chocolate remains soft while the kunafa retains its crisp texture. This modern Dubai-style dessert combines the Middle Eastern tradition of kunafa with the indulgence of chocolate, creating a treat that is rich, crunchy and deeply satisfying.



TIP



Toast kunafa slowly on medium heat; rushing this step prevents even crispness and affects the dessert's signature texture.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR INDIAN TRAVELLERS



For travellers from India, the change may feel less dramatic than it first appears. Many countries—including the United States, Singapore and Australia—already use biometric systems for border control. Still, the disappearance of passport stamps will mark the end of a small travel tradition. Many travellers collect those stamps as souvenirs of journeys—inked reminders of places visited and borders crossed. The EES will quietly

close that chapter. Yet the broader goal is efficiency. Europe receives hundreds of millions of international visitors each year, and border authorities must process growing numbers of passengers while maintaining security. Digital systems promise faster verification once travellers are enrolled. For someone landing in Europe for the second or third time, the new system could actually shorten the immigration process.

‘DIRECTORS SEE THE WHOLE UNIVERSE’

Kumud Mishra shared about why his collaborations with filmmaker Anubhav Sinha always turn out to be special

When you work with a director multiple times, you start to understand how they look at the world and you feel secure, said actor Kumud Mishra about why his collaborations with filmmaker Anubhav Sinha always turn out to be special.

Sinha is among the filmmakers for whom the ‘Thappad’ actor will turn up even for a single scene. Others on his list are Anurag Kashyap, Imtiaz Ali and Nitin Kakkar.

“If you work with someone for years and when you read the story, you get the idea what the director wants from you. Your prep begins with reading the script... If you have any doubts, you have a discussion and it isn’t just about that particular character but about the world he inhabits. We actors, are always self-centred and we approach our characters like that - me, my character, my scene and how do I look in that scene? But the director looks at the whole world. So, when you work with a director whom you know how he looks at the world, you feel very secure as an actor because you are just a part of that world, you are not that world. It is a huge relief,” Mishra told PTI in an interview.

The actor was most recently seen in Sinha’s critically acclaimed ‘Assi’, also starring Taapsee Pannu, Kani Kusruti, Mohd Zeeshan Ayyub and Dia Mirza, a film whose title means 80 in Hindi and represents the number of sexual assault cases reported every day in India. ‘Assi’ was released in February.

Over the years, Mishra has become a regular presence in Sinha’s movies, featuring in the director’s critically acclaimed titles ‘Mulk’ (2018), ‘Article 15’ (2019), ‘Thappad’ (2020), ‘Anek’ (2022) and ‘Netflix’ series ‘IC 814: The Kandahar Hijack’.

The duo first met for a film that is yet to come out. He met Sinha again when the director was working on ‘Mulk’. The film, which explored the alienation of the Muslim community through the story of a family caught in a terror plot, was almost complete, but Sinha still wanted him to cast in the role of a judge. “I initially said no as I thought there was not much in it. But when Anubhav sir is convinced about something, then you cannot escape. I did that role and after that, we have worked regularly.”

In ‘Thappad’, Mishra earned a lot of acclaim for his portrayal of an empathetic father who stands

by his daughter when she decides to divorce her husband after being slapped. But the actor considers it among the most challenging roles of his career. “I found it very hard to get into the character in ‘Thappad’... ‘Ek accha father’ (A good father); it is such a generic term. There is nothing like a good father; it is just one part of an individual... I was struggling a lot, but I was not able to tell him anything... It was my personal struggle.”

Mishra said Sinha’s process of filmmaking is quite unique as the director involves everyone in it. “If he has a doubt, he will ask for your opinion or if he is shooting and you are around... He called me and asked my opinion, but I said, ‘Humm’. I was lost in my own character (‘Thappad’) and he thought I was not happy. I don’t know how he got this in his head. But he told me later,” Mishra recalled.

Mishra said he found the ‘sur’ of the character after he performed his scenes with Ratna Pathak Shah, who played his wife in the movie.

“She is a great actor. I was struggling till then, but when she started saying her lines, everything fell into place for me. When Anubhav asked me later, ‘Are you not happy with this character?’ I said, ‘How can this be possible?’ I was struggling to get into this character. So maybe I couldn’t express myself. I was lost in myself,” he recalled.

In ‘Assi’,

SINHA IS AMONG THE FILMMAKERS FOR WHOM HE WILL TURN UP EVEN FOR A SINGLE SCENE



Mishra portrayed Kartik, a man haunted by the sexual assault of his colleague’s wife, prompting him to question the failures of both legal and social systems. According to the 58-year-old actor, Sinha’s cinema always sparks discussion and that is important in a society where the space for discussion is shrinking.

“I think there cannot be a bigger reward for a filmmaker than a film sparking conversation, whether it was ‘Article 15’, ‘Thappad’, ‘Bheed’ or ‘IC814’. That, in itself, is a big advantage... There is always a discussion, sometimes people get divided also, but it is very interesting because we are living in a society where there is no space for discussion. But in a beautiful society, there are always different ideas, discussions; we agree on some things and we don’t agree on others. So, we leave it open until our understanding becomes more mature. Anubhav’s films are compelling in the way they reignite important conversations,” Mishra said.

The actor has collaborated twice with both Kashyap (‘That Girl in Yellow Boots’, ‘Nishaanchi’) and Ali (‘Rockstar’, ‘Amar Singh Chamkila’) and three times with Kakkar for his comedies ‘Filmistan’, ‘Jawaani Jaaneman’ and ‘Ram Singh Charlie’.

His character of Khatana Bhai in ‘Rockstar’ still lives in public memory, especially the dialogue where his character scolds Ranbir Kapoor’s Janardhan Jakhar and tells him there is no art without pain and heartbreak, which is popular on social media. Reminded about that scene, Mishra said he had fond memories of working on the 2011 film.

“If you really look at the dialogue, it’s beautiful writing. If some other actor had said that dialogue, it’d have had the same effect,” he said. PTI

‘Always been lauded and loved by people for choices I made’

Divya Dutta is ‘very stubborn’ about her choices and loves breaking moulds the industry tries to put her in



RAVI BANSAL

With a career that has spanned three decades and many critically lauded performances, Divya Dutta said she is ‘very stubborn’ about her choices and loves breaking moulds the industry tries to put her in, something that has kept her growing as an actress.

The actress, who has impressed with performances in movies such as ‘Veer-Zaara’, ‘Delhi-6’, ‘Badlapur’, ‘Manto’, ‘Special 26’ and ‘Heroine’, believes that staying relevant means constantly venturing into uncharted space.

“I’m very stubborn and one should be if you want to be a very happy actor. See, it’s your choices - what do you want in life? I want to grow as an actor. I want to keep growing. It’s been 30 years and I think I’ll be here all my life. And I cannot be here until I keep rediscovering myself. Until I feel, ‘Oh, something new’. And that can only happen if you convey this message to whosoever it may concern that you do not want to do what they want you to do. You want to do what you want to do. So, for that, there are a lot of nos, which isn’t easy. And yes, you require loads of patience for it. It’s not easy to say no. But I think lots of nos make a great yes,” Dutta told PTI in an interview.

The National Film Award-winning actress said it wasn’t easy to navigate an industry that never quite knew what to do with her, but she is glad that she stayed the course and carved out a space for herself.

“I’ve always been lauded and loved by people for the choices I’ve made. It’s the industry that I don’t know, strangely, is stuck with, ‘Where do I put her in the image?’ But I’m like, ‘Don’t do it’. If the audience isn’t putting me in an image, so why are you doing that? So, I love breaking those shackles. What happened throughout my career, be it ‘Delhi 6’, ‘Veer Zara’, ‘Stanley Ka Dabba’ and ‘Badlapur’, I tried to bring layers to my characters and that’s something people really loved,” she added.

The actress recently starred in ‘Chiraiya’, which is currently streaming on ‘JioHotstar’. In the show, Dutta plays Kamlesh, a contented traditional daughter-in-law whose world is upended when her younger sister-in-law reveals she has been subjected to marital rape.

The series is set in Lucknow and is an official Hindi adaptation of the Bengali series ‘Sampurna’ (2022). It is based on an idea by Soumyabrata Rakshit, created by Divy Nidhi Sharma, directed by Shashant Shah and produced by ‘SVF Entertainment’.

The 48-year-old actress said the show is not about blaming anyone in particular, but about the conditioning. “It’s more societal than it’s about anything else and the show is only trying to tell a story. It’s trying to tell us that we’ve been conditioned to a few things that need to get out of our systems,” she said.



The actress recently starred in ‘Chiraiya’

The actress said the show tries to hold a mirror to these issues that have long gone unquestioned in Indian households. “We are brought up on saying, ‘Ladki ki naa me hi uski haan chupi hai?’ And because of this mindset, many people don’t even ask for consent. Two, we don’t take the consent of our own partners. I believe it is important to ask, ‘Whether it is your wife or girlfriend - ‘Is it okay for you?’ Two people have decided to spend the rest of their lives together and it is important that there is mutual respect between them. The third thing is communication. There should be a conversation between a man and a woman. This show caters to that rather than anything else,” she said.

Asked whether cinema in general has also normalised wooing a girl even if she says no, Dutta said society will always reflect cinema and cinema will always reflect the society.

“We cannot say they did this and that’s how we learnt it. No, it is for you, again, to pick up what you want to pick. You’re watching very gory films, are you doing that? You’re watching a lot of action. Are you doing that? No, you’re picking what you want to do. You enjoyed the film, but you’re not taking it back home to do something about it. So, I think it’s for the people to take what they want to take home and I’m sure they’ll take a lot from the show.”

On playing Kamlesh, Dutta said she has seen many such characters around her in life. “They are women who are very happy with what they have been conditioned to. Kamlesh is a very happy woman. Her husband loves her. Everything is going for her. Her in-laws love her. And that’s what a normal woman would like. Until that foundation, she has been totally shaken up,” she said.

Dutta said it was important to show Kamlesh was unaware of the concept of consent in marriage. “Because somebody said that I’m not comfortable, a new concept came into her life. So that, I think, was a very difficult layer to bring into place. So, to change that and to stand by somebody you have just gotten to know and you have kind of a rivalry with her.” AGENCIES

WHAT’S COMING NEXT?

From ‘Hui Gumm Yaadein...’ to ‘Big Mistakes’, here is a selection of new OTT offerings for you to enjoy

OUR CORRESPONDENT

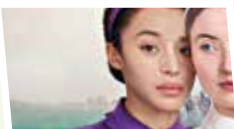
Ranging from drama, action, thriller and romance, enjoy the week with new films and shows from ‘Sony LIV’ (‘Hui Gumm Yaadein...’), ‘Jio Hotstar’ (‘The Testaments’), ‘Prime Video’ (‘The Boys’ S5) and ‘Netflix’ (‘18th Rose’ and ‘Big Mistakes’).

HUI GUMM YAADEIN...

To air on April 6, the new ‘Sony LIV’ series will follow Dr Dev Mehta’s unique approach to diagnosis and his second chance at life. The show will focus on dramatic and emotional stories, often involving patients seeking his help.



THE TESTAMENTS



Starring Chase Infiniti, Lucy Halliday and others, the ‘Hulu’ series, to air digitally on ‘Jio Hotstar’ too, is a sequel to the hit series ‘The Handmaid’s Tale’. To stream on April 8, it follows a new generation of young women in Gilead to grapple with the bleak future that awaits them.

THE BOYS S5

The final season of the highly anticipated hit ‘Prime Video’ series is set to be released on April 8, where everything is in shambles; nobody has any idea of what happens next and it is more destructive than ever!



18TH ROSE



The highly awaited reunion of the much-loved K-pop band finally makes its return on March 27 in the form of a new documentary, titled ‘BTS: Return’. After a long hiatus, the boys come with their new resilience and a promise to hype up their fans.

BIG MISTAKES

The ‘Netflix’ comedy series follows two incapable siblings - after being blackmailed to work for some dangerous men - working as the most disorganised duo in an organised crime. It’ll release on April 9.

